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Susulung king Pyalung: Describing the Lived Professional Experiences of Psychologists in

Luzon on Adolescent Digital Well-Being in Gaming Environments

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HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Abstract**

Adolescent gaming is widely debated, yet how licensed psychologists judge whether an adolescent's gaming supports or undermines well-being has seldom been described. This phenomenological study described the lived professional experiences of seven PRC-licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon regarding adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments. Five participants were interviewed, and two answered an open-ended written questionnaire. Using Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis, 203 extracts were coded under 86 codes and organized into 15 themes. The psychologists encountered gaming mostly behind other presenting concerns, read it by its function rather than its frequency, and defined digital well-being as balanced, controlled play rather than the absence of gaming, although one participant located the harm in screen exposure itself. They weighed the adolescent's emotional state and basic needs, the family, online peers, and the game's content and cost as interlocking factors whose weight differs per adolescent. In practice, they saw relief, connection, and skills alongside disrupted sleep, self-care, and family life, often in the same adolescent; named parents and the adolescent's commitment to change as their main challenges; and responded by understanding the adolescent first, then regulating play gradually, offering offline alternatives, and providing psychoeducation. Interpreted through Bronfenbrenner and Morris's (2007) bioecological model, the findings show that adolescent gaming calls for contextual professional judgment rather than rules based on screen time, with implications for school-based mental health services under Republic Act No. 12080.

Keywords: adolescent digital well-being, gaming, licensed psychologists, lived professional experience, bioecological model, thematic analysis



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HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Susulong king Pyalung: Describing the Lived Professional Experiences of Psychologists in
Luzon on Adolescent Digital Well-Being in Gaming Environments****Chapter 1****Background of the Study**

Gaming has become one of the most pervasive features of adolescent life, now functioning as a space where young people build friendships, express themselves, develop skills, and share everyday experiences. In contemporary contexts, gaming typically refers to engagement with digital or video games across devices such as consoles, computers, and mobile phones, whether played online or offline (Gottfried & Sidoti, 2024). Dienlin and Johannes (2020) emphasize that the psychological impact of digital technology depends more on how and why it is used than on the technology itself, making gaming an increasingly important area of psychological inquiry. Because these platforms have grown so quickly and are used so widely, there is a heightened need to understand how gaming relates to adolescent development.

The scale of adolescent gaming is well documented, although it varies by region and measure. In the United States, 85% of teens reported playing video games (Gottfried & Sidoti, 2024). In the Health Behaviour in School-aged Children study reported by the World Health Organization (WHO) Regional Office for Europe (2024), 34% of adolescents played digital games daily and 12% were at risk of problematic gaming. These estimates describe their own surveyed populations and cannot be applied directly to Filipino adolescents, but they show a consistent pattern: playing games is common, while problematic involvement concerns a much smaller group. Gaming therefore spans a wide range of experiences rather than leading uniformly to harm.



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This variation in adolescent gaming experiences highlights a larger, worldwide discussion regarding the complex relationship between digital technology and youth development. According to UNICEF Office of Research – Innocenti (2022), digital technologies are now deeply embedded in adolescent development, creating a combination of opportunities and risks; exposure alone does not automatically translate into harm or benefit, and digital experiences are best understood within a developmental and social context. Yet much existing research remains concern-centric, so that the conditions under which gaming supports rather than undermines development remain comparatively underexplored (Meriläinen et al., 2023).

A balanced and context-sensitive understanding of adolescent digital experiences aligns with several United Nations Sustainable Development Goals. It supports SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-Being) through its focus on adolescent mental health and healthy digital engagement; SDG 4 (Quality Education) through the role of schools and school-based mental health services in supporting students who game; and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions) through its relevance to the institutions increasingly asked to respond to online safety and youth well-being.

The Philippines provides an especially relevant setting for this discussion. At the start of 2025, internet penetration in the country was estimated at 83.8%, or approximately 97.5 million people (Kemp, 2025). These figures describe internet users in general rather than adolescents or gamers specifically, but they establish the scale of the connected environment in which Filipino adolescents now grow up.

Philippine studies point to both concerns and benefits. Labana et al. (2020) reported an association, not a causal link, between problematic online gaming and depressive symptoms among adolescents in Manila, and Llabore et al. (2023) examined gaming in relation to adolescents' mental health and behavioral status. On the benefit side, Encallado et al. (2024) found

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that Filipino senior high school students described enjoyment, social connection, and stress relief through gaming alongside costs such as disrupted sleep and missed meals. Their gaming, in other words, was rarely all good or all bad. Gaming is neither a uniform threat nor a uniform benefit but a complex and individualized experience whose outcomes depend on context, motivation, and support systems. This study examines that tension through the two ideas at its center: adolescent digital well-being and gaming environments.

The debate over adolescent gaming took on new urgency in mid-2026. After a fatal shooting at a secondary school in Tacloban City in June 2026, the Senate Committee on Women, Children, Family Relations and Gender Equality opened an inquiry into child safety in digital spaces (Bacelonia, 2026). Lawmakers did not blame gaming itself. They pointed instead to organized online groups that reach minors through gaming platforms by exploiting a young person's need to belong, and they stated that the reported links to the case were still being verified (Bacelonia, 2026). Filipino clinicians had already drawn a similar distinction: experts from the University of the Philippines–Philippine General Hospital cautioned that no causal link between gaming and real-world aggression has been shown and that practitioners must weigh other factors, such as the family environment, conflict at home, and unmoderated contact with strangers online (Santos, 2026). The national discussion therefore arrived where the international research already stood: the important question is not whether an adolescent plays games, but with whom, for what reason, and under what circumstances. Answering that question for one particular adolescent is not something a hearing or a law can do; it requires professional judgment about that specific young person.

Understanding this context matters more now that schools and mental health institutions carry greater responsibility for adolescent well-being. Republic Act No. 11036 (2018) established



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a national mental health policy, and Republic Act No. 12080 (2024) strengthened school-based mental health services through Care Centers, counseling, and referral systems in basic education. Republic Act No. 10029 (2010) regulates the practice of psychology and limits it to professionals registered with the Professional Regulation Commission (PRC). In practice, a concern about an adolescent's gaming may first be noticed by a teacher, parent, or guidance counselor and may be referred to a licensed psychologist when it exceeds what school-based support can address. The judgment made at that point, whether an adolescent's gaming reflects ordinary development or a clinical concern, shapes what follows: continued monitoring, counseling, family intervention, or referral for formal assessment. Republic Act No. 12080 also recognizes the roles of registered guidance counselors and other qualified professionals, so licensed psychologists are not the only professionals involved; they are, however, the professionals whose experiences this study set out to describe.

The professionals who receive these concerns are few. The Philippines has 3.9 mental health workers for every 100,000 people, and psychologists make up only 7.7% of them; for children and adolescents specifically, the country has 0.3 mental health workers for every 100,000 young people, compared with a global average of 1.5 (World Health Organization [WHO], 2025). Where professional judgment is concentrated in so few practitioners, understanding how that judgment is formed becomes correspondingly valuable.

This study is set in Luzon, the largest of the country's three major island groups, and its setting is defined by the communities in which the participants practice or which they serve rather than by a single institution. The researchers are based in Pampanga, where most of the participants also practice. The setting was widened from Pampanga to Luzon during data collection so that eligible psychologists practicing in other provinces could take part. Luzon is therefore a



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geographic scope of eligibility, not a single cultural or professional environment, and the study attends to the conditions of each participant's practice rather than treating the island group as uniform.

Taken together, this research describes adolescent gaming as widespread, intensive, and genuinely debated, and it consistently shows that outcomes depend on the conditions surrounding a young person rather than on how much they play (Dienlin & Johannes, 2020). Deciding what those conditions mean for one adolescent, however, is a professional judgment rather than a research finding, and how that judgment is made has seldom been described. Filipino practitioners have commented publicly on adolescent gaming (Santos, 2026), but their views have not been studied systematically. The few studies that ask practitioners directly come from outside the Philippines and address related problems rather than gaming (Lo et al., 2021), while reviews of gaming research continue to measure effects instead of examining how professionals interpret cases (Alzahrani & Griffiths, 2024). The gap is also geographic. The Philippine studies reviewed here were conducted in Metro Manila (Labana et al., 2020; Llabore et al., 2023) and in Mindanao (Encallado et al., 2024), and they studied adolescents rather than the professionals who assess them. Within the literature reviewed, no study has described how licensed psychologists in Luzon encounter, interpret, and respond to adolescent gaming.

Therefore, this study aimed to describe the lived professional experiences of PRC-licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon regarding adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments. Insight into how these practitioners understand, assess, and respond to gaming-related concerns can inform more context-sensitive support for adolescents in schools, families, and mental health services, including the school-based Care Centers established under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024).



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Review of Related Literature**

This review examines existing literature on adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments, focusing on the concepts, debates, and professional context on which this study builds. The literature is organized thematically and arranged from broad, global ideas toward the local Philippine and professional setting, so that each area lays the groundwork for the one that follows.

The review moves through nine areas. It first establishes adolescence as a developmental stage and the place of digital technology within it, then defines the study's two focal concepts, digital well-being and gaming environments. It then examines problematic gaming and gaming disorder as recognized in formal diagnostic systems, followed by the contested evidence on whether gaming benefits or harms adolescents. These areas lead to the study's guiding perspective, the configurational view, which holds that adolescent outcomes are shaped by the interaction of many factors rather than by gaming exposure alone. The review then situates this perspective within Filipino cultural psychology and locally situated meanings, within the legal and professional context of the licensed psychologists whose experiences this study describes, and finally within the strategies these professionals may use to support adolescents. Together, these areas define the concepts the study depends on, clarify the debates it enters, and point toward where the literature remains thin: the interpretive judgments of the professionals who work with adolescents directly.

Adolescence as a Developmental Stage

Adolescents are often the early adopters and innovators of new technologies, which can create both risks and opportunities that shape their health, well-being, and social development. Dahl et al. (2018) describe this stage as a transition from childhood marked by puberty, learning,



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adaptation, and neurobiological development, during which developmental trajectories can shift in both positive and negative directions. These experiences unfold within specific social, family, peer, and cultural contexts, and today they are increasingly mediated by digital technology. According to Dienlin and Johannes (2020), digital technology encompasses a wide range of devices and services, with smartphones acting as a central metamedium that integrates the functions of many other platforms into adolescents' daily lives. A metamedium is a digital computing platform that enables different forms of media to be created, integrated, and combined within a single technological system (Jensen, 2016). Because adolescence is a period of heightened developmental sensitivity, what matters is not simply how much adolescents use technology but how they engage with it, a distinction captured by the concept of digital well-being examined next.

The Definition and Importance of Adolescent Digital Well-Being

Feerrar (2022) describes digital well-being as an individual's capacity to consciously maintain their physical, emotional, and social health while using technology in everyday life. Building on this, Vanden Abeele (2021) frames digital well-being not as a matter of screen time but as a dynamic state of equilibrium: a continuous, subjective balance shaped by an individual's coping strategies, social environment, and immediate situation rather than by any fixed metric.

Laffier et al. (2025) argue that fostering digital wellness during adolescence supports youth well-being and healthy communities by building skills such as emotional regulation, self-awareness, and intentional use of technology. Their argument places the source of digital well-being in how technology is used and regulated rather than in the amount of use. This distinction matters for the present study because it is the same distinction a practitioner must make when assessing an adolescent who games: the question is not whether the adolescent plays, but whether the adolescent's play leaves physical, emotional, and social health intact.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***The Nature, Elements, and Influence of Gaming Environments***

A gaming environment is more than entertainment software. Giardina et al. (2024) characterize gaming environments as immersive virtual spaces that individuals may experience as compensatory or psychologically absorbing alternatives to the physical world, offering relief, escape, or a sense of connection. Sussman et al. (2018) add a neurobiological dimension, explaining that these environments engage the brain's reward pathways through immediate and repeated gratification, which is part of what makes them so engaging and, for some adolescents, difficult to disengage from. Gaming environments are therefore best understood as interactive spaces whose design, social features, and reward structures actively shape how adolescents engage with them. Whether that engagement proves beneficial or harmful, however, depends on a wider set of factors, beginning with the line between healthy involvement and gaming disorder.

Problematic Gaming and the Recognition of Gaming Disorder

Problematic gaming refers broadly to patterns of gaming associated with difficulties in personal, family, social, educational, or occupational functioning (King & Delfabbro, 2019). While recognizing that millions of people enjoy gaming as a safe pastime, Griffiths et al. (2017) maintain that problematic gaming is a genuine phenomenon that, in its severe form, constitutes disordered gaming. Problematic gaming is therefore not synonymous with a formal diagnosis. Gaming disorder in the ICD-11 involves impaired control over gaming, increasing priority given to gaming over other interests and daily activities, and continuation despite negative consequences, with significant impairment in personal, family, social, educational, or occupational functioning (WHO, 2020). That recognition, however, is not uniform: gaming disorder is a formal diagnosis in the ICD-11, whereas the DSM-5 places internet gaming disorder among conditions requiring further study (Király et al., 2022; Musetti et al., 2025).



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The difficulty is not only that the systems differ. Gaming also carries recognized cognitive, social, and emotional benefits, so the line being drawn is not between a harmful activity and a harmless one. According to Columb et al. (2022), a key challenge for clinicians is differentiating healthy, enthusiastic gaming from gaming disorder, because a strong interest in gaming alone does not indicate a problematic condition. Enthusiasm or long playing time does not establish the disorder; impairment does. Whether gaming ultimately supports or undermines well-being is therefore decided less by gaming itself than by the balance of individual and environmental factors surrounding it, the positive and negative influences examined next.

The Contested Evidence on Gaming and Adolescent Well-Being

The evidence on whether gaming helps or harms adolescents does not point in a single direction, with outcomes ranging from beneficial to harmful. On the positive side, Nagata et al. (2026) note that video games can offer genuine developmental and health benefits, particularly when play is driven by authentic interest and paired with effective self-regulation. At the environmental level, Schneider et al. (2017) found that warm, cohesive family environments with positive parent-child relationships are associated with lower levels of problematic gaming.

The same research, however, documents clear risks. Uçur and Dönmez (2021) identified emotional dysregulation and low perceived social support as key predictors of problematic gaming among adolescents, who may turn to games as a way to escape or manage difficult emotions. Schneider et al. (2017) likewise linked weak parental monitoring, low involvement, and poor communication to higher risk.

This mixed evidence is the heart of the difficulty: gaming outcomes cannot be explained by exposure alone. Dienlin and Johannes (2020) argue that the effects of digital media depend on individual characteristics, patterns of use, and surrounding context rather than on the technology

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itself. Gaming and well-being are therefore best understood within the broader context of family, peers, school, and online community, which provides the basis for the configurational perspective examined next.

The Configurational View of Adolescent Digital Well-Being

The configurational view of adolescent digital well-being is grounded in Bronfenbrenner's Bioecological Systems Theory (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007). Derived from his earlier Ecological Systems Theory (Bronfenbrenner, 1979), the bioecological model holds that development results from the continuous interaction between an individual's biological characteristics and the environmental systems in which they are embedded, from the immediate family and community to broader social and cultural contexts.

The earlier form of the theory establishes the environmental structure on which the later model builds. Bronfenbrenner (1979) describes the developing person as situated within a set of nested systems, each contained within the next. The microsystem consists of the settings in which the person participates directly, such as the family, the peer group, and the school. The mesosystem consists of the relations among those settings, so that what happens at home and what happens at school are understood in relation to one another rather than separately. The exosystem consists of settings in which the person does not participate but which nonetheless affect them, such as a parent's workplace or, in the present context, the design and moderation decisions made by a gaming company. Features of a game that the adolescent meets directly during play, however, belong to the adolescent's immediate experience rather than to the exosystem. The macrosystem consists of the overarching cultural patterns, belief systems, and values within which the other systems are embedded. The chronosystem, added in later formulations, accounts for change over time, both in the person and in the environment.

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Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) organize the mature form of the theory around the Process, Person, Context, and Time (PPCT) model. At its core are proximal processes, the recurring interactions between a person and their environment that drive development. Their effect depends on four interrelated elements: Process (the proximal interactions themselves), Person (the individual's biological and personal characteristics), Context (the nested systems described above, from microsystem to macrosystem), and Time (the timing and duration of these processes across development and history).

Applied to this study, the PPCT model provides a configurational lens. Adolescent gaming and digital well-being are shaped not by any single influence but by the interaction of the adolescent's characteristics, their relationships with family, peers, and schools, their online environments, and the wider culture over time. It is precisely this interaction that psychologists are positioned to interpret. In this study, the model serves as a sensitizing perspective for interpreting the contexts psychologists describe; because the study collected professional accounts rather than developmental observations, it does not test the model's mechanisms.

Filipino Cultural Psychology and Locally Situated Meanings

Filipino psychology offers a culturally grounded lens for describing how Filipino adolescents experience relationships and digital life. Its central framework, *Sikolohiyang Pilipino*, rests on the argument that psychological concepts should be understood from within Filipino experience, culture, and language rather than through Western frameworks alone, with *kapwa*, a shared identity between self and others in contrast to the Western notion of the other as separate from the self, at its core (Enriquez, 1978, as cited in Maninang, 2025). *Kapwa* is enacted through *pakikipagkapwa*, the process of interacting with one's *kapwa* across levels of depth, from the guarded civility of *pakikitungo* to the rapport and ease of *pakikipagpalagayang-loob*; it is this

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depth, not surface civility, that Enriquez treated as the true form Filipino relationships take (Maninang, 2025).

Although *kapwa* is a general Filipino construct, it takes local forms. In Pampanga, where the researchers study and where most of the participants practice, Antonio (2023) found that Kapampangan youth organize care, concern, and communal obligation around the local value cluster of *pamagmasabal*, expressed through *malasakit* (concern), *pakialam* (compassionate concern), *pamisan-metung* (unity), and deference to elders. These values may shape how families read what an adolescent's gaming means for the family's sense of connection and obligation, and they are part of the cultural fabric within which the psychologists who interpret these cases are themselves embedded. Because the study is set in Luzon rather than in one province, however, these concepts are treated as possible interpretive resources rather than as characteristics of every participant, family, or community; cultural meanings are discussed only where the participants' accounts support them.

Licensed Psychologists and Professional Interpretation

The professionals at the center of this study are psychologists licensed by the Professional Regulation Commission. Under the Philippine Psychology Act of 2009, psychology is defined as the scientific study of behavior, and a psychologist is a professional registered with the Commission to deliver psychological services (Republic Act No. 10029, 2010). The license distinguishes registered psychologists from psychometricians and from other professionals who work with adolescents.

Two more recent laws expand the demand for these services. The Mental Health Act (Republic Act No. 11036, 2018) established a national mental health policy and integrated mental health into schools, workplaces, and communities, while the Basic Education Mental Health and



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Well-Being Promotion Act (Republic Act No. 12080, 2024) mandated Care Centers and school-based mental health programs in basic education. Together these laws increase the number of adolescents who may be screened and referred for concerns that include gaming and digital well-being, so that a growing share of interpretive judgments is likely to reach a comparatively small group of licensed professionals.

Clinical and counseling psychology offer examples of the professional practice involved. Clinical psychology emphasizes comprehensive assessment, diagnosis, and treatment of mental and behavioral health (American Psychological Association, 2022a), while counseling psychology places greater emphasis on promoting well-being and helping individuals navigate developmental, educational, and interpersonal concerns through culturally informed practice (American Psychological Association, 2022b). Psychologists in other fields, such as school and guidance work, also serve adolescents, so the present study included licensed psychologists from any field who have professional experience with adolescents.

Yet how these professionals actually interpret adolescent gaming remains underexamined, and what research exists suggests their views are far from uniform. Lo et al. (2021), interviewing practitioners who treat adolescent internet-related concerns, found that they regard family involvement as both essential and challenging and stress the need to tailor support to each case. At the same time, systematic reviews of gaming research have concentrated on its effects on outcomes such as academic performance (Alzahrani & Griffiths, 2024) rather than on how practitioners make sense of these cases. The professional interpretive layer, in other words, remains thinly studied, and it is this layer that the present study examines.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***Strategies for Supporting Adolescent Digital Well-Being***

Because gaming outcomes are shaped by the environment around the adolescent, much of the literature on support focuses on the people and systems surrounding them, especially families. Nielsen et al. (2019), reviewing parental mediation practices, distinguish several approaches: active mediation (talking with the adolescent about their media use), restrictive mediation (setting limits), and co-use. Their review found that no single approach works uniformly, that withdrawing from mediation altogether tends to worsen problems, and that active, communicative involvement shows more promise. The review concerns problematic online screen use broadly rather than gaming alone, but it reflects a wider pattern in the literature, in which warm and communicative parenting is more protective than control alone.

At the clinical level, practitioners increasingly favor approaches that address the adolescent's wider life rather than gaming in isolation. Lo et al. (2021) describe practitioners who draw families into the therapeutic process, combining individual counseling with family sessions to improve communication and relationships. These strategies reflect the same configurational logic that runs through this review: supporting adolescent digital well-being means attending not only to gaming itself but to the relationships and contexts that surround it. How licensed psychologists in Luzon approach these strategies in their own practice is a central concern of the present study.

Synthesis of the Reviewed Literature

The literature reviewed establishes several points that, together, frame this study. Adolescence is a developmental period of both opportunity and vulnerability, increasingly lived through digital technology (Dahl et al., 2018; Dienlin & Johannes, 2020). Digital well-being within this context is best understood not as the absence of screen time but as a dynamic balance between

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the benefits and burdens of digital engagement (Vanden Abeele, 2021), and gaming environments are interactive spaces whose design and reward structures actively shape adolescent experience (Giardina et al., 2024; Sussman et al., 2018).

The evidence on gaming's effects is genuinely mixed. Gaming carries real benefits alongside the risk of gaming disorder, which the ICD-11 recognizes as a diagnosis and the DSM-5 does not (Király et al., 2022; Musetti et al., 2025), and one of the central difficulties for practitioners is telling healthy engagement apart from disordered gaming (Columb et al., 2022). This points to the review's central conclusion: gaming outcomes cannot be explained by exposure alone. Drawing on Bronfenbrenner and Morris's (2007) Bioecological Systems Theory, the literature supports a configurational view in which outcomes emerge from the interaction of the person, their relationships, and their environments over time.

This configuration is not culturally neutral. In the Filipino setting, the relationships and communities that make up an adolescent's environment are often organized around shared identity and communal obligation, captured by the concept of *kapwa* (Enriquez, 1978, as cited in Maninang, 2025), and, in Pampanga, by the Kapampangan value cluster of *pamagmasabal* (Antonio, 2023). These values are part of the environment that may shape how adolescents engage with gaming, and part of what the psychologists who serve these communities may draw on when they interpret it.

What the literature establishes in concept, however, it leaves underexamined in practice. Licensed psychologists are legally positioned to assess and interpret adolescent behavior (Republic Act No. 10029, 2010), yet the little research that exists suggests that practitioners' judgments vary and are shaped by more than evidence alone (Lo et al., 2021), while most gaming research still centers on effects rather than on professional interpretation (Alzahrani & Griffiths, 2024). It is this

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interpretive layer, culturally situated and professionally exercised, together with the strategies these professionals use to support adolescents, that the present study examines. These concerns are developed further through the empirical studies reviewed in the following section.

Review of Related Studies

The following studies are grouped under the areas of the review to which they relate. Each was selected because it addresses one part of the problem the present study takes up: how adolescents experience digital technology and gaming, how gaming environments are designed, how multiple factors combine, and how professionals understand and respond to these cases.

Digital Well-Being in Adolescents' Own Accounts

Bitto Urbanova et al. (2023) conducted a study titled “I Could Do Almost Nothing Without Digital Technology: A Qualitative Exploration of Adolescents’ Perception of the Risks and Challenges of Digital Technology,” addressing a gap in a literature that had focused more on adults and clinical populations than on adolescents’ own experiences. Using consensual qualitative research procedures and thematic analysis, the researchers explored how 15 Slovak adolescents aged 14 to 16 perceive the risks and challenges of daily digital technology use, collecting data through online individual or group interviews and background questionnaires. The study identified four main themes: dependence on the functionality of technology, problematic control, vulnerability in virtual spaces, and health risks. The adolescents were aware of these risks but often struggled with self-regulation and safety measures, which led the researchers to call for targeted digital literacy programs. In relation to this review’s discussion of digital well-being, the study shows that the balance described by Vanden Abeele (2021) is difficult for adolescents to keep on their own, and as a qualitative study of adolescents’ accounts, it offers a methodological reference point for the present study’s analysis of how psychologists make sense of the same experiences.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***Game Design and Problematic Gaming***

Rehbein et al. (2024) introduced the Risk Characteristics Checklist for Games (RCCG), addressing the absence of a standardized tool for evaluating how game features relate to problematic gaming. The researchers combined theoretical work and qualitative analyses of game content with a pilot study of 4,468 students with a mean age of 14.54 years, whose preferred games were rated with the checklist alongside gaming-disorder screening measures. Mandatory social interaction and the number of reward categories within a game showed the strongest associations with gaming-disorder indicators. Because the design was cross-sectional, these are associations rather than causes, and the checklist evaluates games rather than diagnosing players. In relation to this review's discussion of gaming environments, the study grounds the concept empirically: it shows that the design of the environment, and not merely the time spent within it, is related to how adolescents engage with games.

Filipino Adolescents' Gaming Experiences

Encallado et al. (2024) conducted a study titled "Navigating the Digital Playground: Lived Experiences, Risks, and Benefits of Online Gaming among Senior High School Students," responding to the limited qualitative research on how Filipino adolescents make sense of their own gaming. Using a qualitative design, the researchers gathered data through in-depth interviews and focus group discussions with 15 senior high school students from Sto. Tomas National High School in Loreto, Agusan del Sur. Three superordinate themes emerged as drivers of gaming engagement: enjoyment as habitual behavior, social connection through friends, and gaming as a stress-relieving distraction. Alongside these, participants described costs such as disrupted sleep and missed meals, so that their gaming was rarely wholly beneficial or wholly harmful. In relation to this review's discussion of the contested evidence on gaming, the study is the only Philippine

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study among those reviewed and the only one to examine gaming through adolescents' own accounts. It establishes locally what the present study asks psychologists to interpret professionally, while its Mindanao setting leaves Luzon undescribed.

Multiple Factors in a Bioecological Perspective

Yang et al. (2024) conducted a study titled "Multidimensional Predictors of Adolescents' Nonacademic Digital Media Use in the United States: Insights from a Bioecological Perspective." Guided by Bronfenbrenner's PPCT model, the researchers conducted a secondary analysis of the 2016 National Survey of Children's Health, in which parents or primary caregivers reported on 22,454 adolescents. The analysis covered process factors such as parent-child communication and family meals, person factors such as age, sleep, physical activity, anxiety, and depression, and contextual factors such as parental emotional support, school safety, and family socioeconomic status. Greater family interaction, participation in school and community activities, adequate sleep, physical activity, supportive school environments, and parental emotional support were associated with lower nonacademic digital media use, while older age, anxiety, and depressive symptoms were associated with greater use. Because the outcome was caregiver-reported screen time rather than gaming-specific well-being, the study does not measure the present study's phenomenon directly. In relation to this review's configurational view, however, it supports the position that adolescent digital experiences reflect the combined influence of individual and socioecological factors rather than any single factor.

Professional Roles across Psychology Specialties

Young and Young (2019) used secondary analysis of survey data to compare the demographics, professional activities, theoretical orientations, values, career satisfaction, and views on the Scopes of Practice of clinical and counseling psychologists in South Africa. The study



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analyzed responses from 1,105 registered psychologists, comprising 877 clinical and 228 counseling psychologists, and found that the two specialties were more similar than different, sharing many professional roles, orientations, and levels of career satisfaction despite differences in areas such as assessment and research emphasis. Because its national registration system differs from the Philippine one, the study cannot determine eligibility or scope of practice in the Philippines. In relation to this review's discussion of licensed psychologists, however, the overlap it documents supports the present study's decision to include licensed psychologists across fields as informants on adolescents' psychological experiences, a decision further warranted in the Philippine setting by Republic Act No. 10029 (2010), which registers psychologists without dividing them by specialty.

Practitioners' Views of Family Involvement

Lo et al. (2021) conducted a study titled "A Qualitative Study of Practitioners' Views on Family Involvement in Treatment Process of Adolescent Internet Addiction," addressing the shortage of research that examines intervention from the practitioner's point of view rather than the adolescent's. The researchers interviewed ten practitioners in Hong Kong who work with adolescents experiencing internet addiction and analyzed the transcripts thematically. Three themes were synthesized: family involvement is both challenging and essential, effective work shifts the focus from the adolescent alone to the relationships around them, and services must be individualized because cases are heterogeneous. The researchers also reported that recruitment was difficult because few professionals specialize in this area, and most of their participants were social workers rather than licensed psychologists. In relation to this review's discussion of support strategies, this is the closest existing work to the present study in both population and purpose, and

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its stated limits mark what the present study takes up: a Philippine setting, a licensed psychologist population, and gaming specifically rather than internet use in general.

Synthesis of the Reviewed Studies

Taken together, the six studies converge on the position this study adopts, and they mark the point at which existing work stops. Bitto Urbanova et al. (2023) and Encallado et al. (2024) establish that adolescents experience digital technology and gaming as neither wholly beneficial nor wholly harmful, describing gains and costs within the same accounts. Rehbein et al. (2024) show that part of this variation is associated with the environment itself, since specific design features rather than time spent are linked to problematic use. Yang et al. (2024), working directly from the bioecological model, extend the same logic outward and find that process, person, and contextual factors jointly relate to adolescent digital media use. Young and Young (2019) establish that psychologists across specialties share the competencies required to read such arrangements, and Lo et al. (2021) show that practitioners do precisely this, treating cases as heterogeneous and drawing families into the work rather than addressing the behavior in isolation.

Two limits run through the whole set. Only Encallado et al. (2024) was conducted in the Philippines, and it was carried out in Mindanao among adolescents rather than practitioners. Only Lo et al. (2021) examined practitioners, and it was conducted in Hong Kong, drew mainly on social workers, and addressed internet use rather than gaming. Existing research therefore describes how adolescents experience gaming, how gaming environments are designed, and which factors combine to shape outcomes, while the professional judgment that turns all of this into a decision about one adolescent remains unexamined in a Philippine setting. It is that judgment, as exercised by licensed psychologists in Luzon, that the present study takes up.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Research Framework**

This study was guided by the Bioecological Systems Theory of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007), organized around the Process, Person, Context, and Time (PPCT) model. The theory holds that development results from progressively more complex reciprocal interactions, called proximal processes, between a developing person and the people, objects, and symbols in the immediate environment, and that the force of these interactions depends on the characteristics of the person, the contexts in which they occur, and their timing. The theory suits this study because it explains the central puzzle of the field: the same amount of gaming can lead to very different outcomes because exposure is not the deciding factor; the surrounding configuration is.

Applied to adolescent digital well-being, gaming can be read as a recurring interaction whose meaning depends on the adolescent and the systems around them. At the person level, an adolescent's emotional regulation, developmental stage, and motivations interact directly with the gaming experience. Within the microsystem, family communication, parental mediation, and the peers the adolescent plays with shape whether play provides connection or replaces it. Within the mesosystem, agreement or conflict between household and school expectations shapes whether an adolescent's gaming is integrated into or exiled from ordinary life. Within the exosystem, decisions about platform design and moderation, made in settings the adolescent never enters, shape the experience without the adolescent having chosen it. Within the macrosystem, Filipino cultural values such as *kapwa*, and local meanings such as the Kapampangan value cluster of *pamagmasabal*, may shape which behaviors families read as distress and which as ordinary adolescence. Within the chronosystem, the post-pandemic normalization of continuous connectivity and the current national discussion of youth, gaming, and online safety form the historical moment in which present judgments about adolescent gaming are made.



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Because the participants in this study are psychologists rather than adolescents, the theory was used as the lens through which their professional interpretations were understood. When a psychologist explains why one adolescent's gaming is healthy and another's is a concern, the psychologist is, in effect, reading the ecological configuration around each young person. The framework therefore offered a principled way to organize what psychologists notice, weigh, and recommend.

The theory guided what the researchers listened for; it did not decide in advance what would be found. Initial codes were developed from the participants' own words before they were related to the PPCT model, and accounts that did not fit the bioecological pattern were reported as they were rather than adjusted to fit the model (see Chapter 2). The framework is a sensitizing lens for interpretation, not a causal model that the study tested. Figure 1 presents this configuration together with the interpretive position the psychologist occupies in relation to it.

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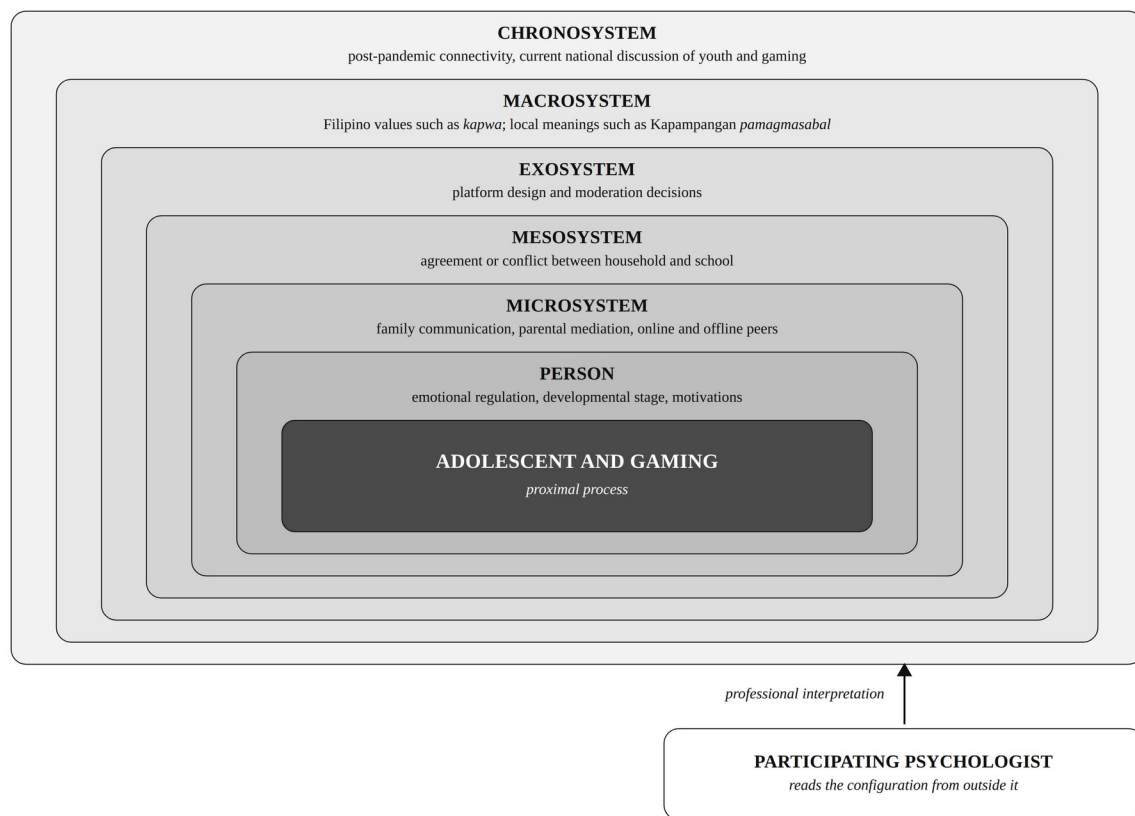


Figure 1. *Bioecological Configuration of Adolescent Gaming and the Psychologist's Interpretive Position*

Note. Adapted from the bioecological model of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007). The figure organizes possible interpretations; it is not a tested causal model.

Research Paradigm

The research paradigm follows an Input–Process–Output model (Figure 2). The input consisted of the accounts of PRC-licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon; the study's two focal concepts, adolescent digital well-being and gaming environments; the Bioecological Systems Theory of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) as the guiding framework; and the semi-structured interview guide and its written questionnaire version as instruments. The process was a phenomenological inquiry: in-depth interviews and open-ended written questionnaires analyzed through Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis, with negative-case analysis, thick description, transcript checks, and an audit trail supporting trustworthiness (Lincoln

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& Guba, 1985). The output is a set of themes describing how psychologists encounter and interpret adolescent gaming (SOP 1), the factors they weigh (SOP 2), and the benefits and concerns, challenges, and strategies they describe in practice (SOP 3), yielding practitioner-informed insights that may inform school Care Centers under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024). Reflexivity was maintained across all three stages. In this paradigm, “process” refers to the research procedure and not to the Process component of the PPCT model.

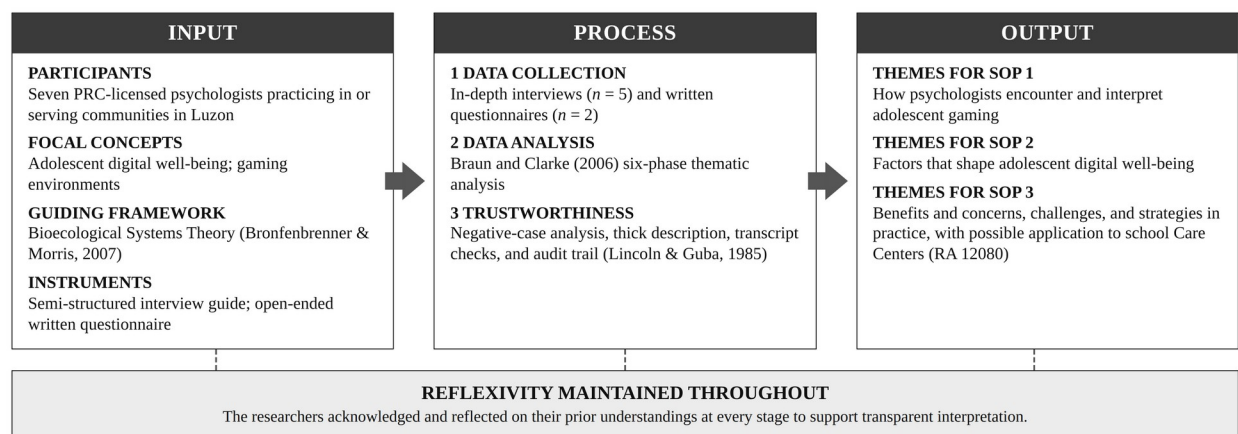


Figure 2. Paradigm on the Research Titled “Susulong king Pylung: Describing the Lived Professional Experiences of Psychologists in Luzon on Adolescent Digital Well-Being in Gaming Environments”

Statement of the Problem (GSOP)

The purpose of this study is to describe the lived professional experiences of licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon as they encounter, interpret, and respond to adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments. For this study, adolescent digital well-being in relation to gaming was generally defined as an experiential state of balance between connectivity and disconnectivity in which technology is used in ways that support physical, mental, and emotional health (Vanden Abeele, 2021); its meaning in practice was left for the participants to describe. The participating psychologists were generally defined as PRC-licensed professionals from any field of psychology who have worked professionally with adolescents, such as clinical

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psychologists, who focus on assessment, diagnosis, and treatment, and counseling psychologists, who emphasize personal, interpersonal, and developmental adjustment (American Psychological Association, 2022a, 2022b).

Specific Statement of the Problem (SSOP)

Specifically, this study sought to answer the following questions:

1. How do psychologists in Luzon describe their lived professional experiences of encountering and interpreting adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?
2. How do psychologists in Luzon describe the factors that shape adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?
3. How do psychologists in Luzon describe their practice in responding to gaming-related concerns among adolescents, in terms of: (a) the benefits and the concerns they identify in adolescents' gaming; (b) the challenges they face as practitioners; and (c) the strategies they employ?

Scope and Delimitation of the Study

This study described the lived professional experiences of PRC-licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon regarding adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments. Seven psychologists took part between September and October 2026: five through semi-structured interviews and two through an open-ended written questionnaire. Five practice in Pampanga, one in Metro Manila and Bulacan, and one in Nueva Ecija, so the sample is concentrated in Pampanga and does not cover most provinces of Luzon. The study used a qualitative phenomenological design and did not employ quantitative methods or other qualitative designs such as case study, ethnography, or narrative inquiry.

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The study was limited to the accounts of licensed psychologists. It did not include adolescents, parents, educators, guidance counselors, psychometricians, or other mental health professionals as participants. Adolescents, as used in this study, refers to learners of junior and senior high school age, the group served by the school-based mental health programs under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024); accounts that participants gave about adult or younger clients were used only as comparisons and are identified as such. The study focused on gaming; other digital activities, such as social media use and scrolling, appear only where participants raised them for comparison.

The study did not diagnose gaming disorder, measure adolescents' well-being, establish causal relationships, estimate prevalence, or evaluate the effectiveness of interventions. Because the accounts come from seven practitioners describing their own practice settings, the findings offer an in-depth understanding of these participants' experiences and are not intended to be generalized to all psychologists in Luzon. Implications for school Care Centers under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024) are presented as possible applications rather than as findings from an evaluation of those centers.

Significance of the Study

The study offers practitioner-informed insights for students, parents and guardians, educators, school administrators, psychologists and other mental health practitioners, and future researchers. Its value lies in describing how a small group of licensed professionals make sense of adolescent gaming within their practice, so its insights are best read alongside wider research and professional guidance.

Students. Adolescent students may gain a clearer picture of what a healthy balance between gaming and well-being looks like. The findings may help them recognize when their own



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gaming supports them and when it may signal a concern worth raising with a trusted adult or guidance counselor.

Parents and Guardians. Parents may better understand why adolescents play and how professionals judge when gaming has become a problem. This may support calmer communication at home and limits that adolescents are more likely to accept, while taking into account the family's own circumstances and cultural values.

Educators. Teachers may better understand how gaming interacts with school life and peer relationships, which can help them respond to students' sleepiness, absences, or withdrawal with informed concern rather than blanket assumptions about gaming.

School Administrators. Administrators may use the findings in designing student mental health programs, including the Care Centers and referral services required under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024). The findings do not by themselves establish an effective program, but they describe what practitioners consider when gaming becomes a concern.

Psychologists and Mental Health Practitioners. Practitioners, including guidance counselors, may compare their own case-based assessment, family involvement, and strategies with those described by their colleagues, supporting reflective and culturally informed practice.

Future Researchers. The study offers context-specific findings, a documented coding record, and identified gaps that later studies can build on through broader recruitment across Luzon, direct accounts from adolescents and parents, and the development and evaluation of interventions.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Chapter 2****Method****Research Design**

This study used a qualitative research design, specifically a phenomenological design. Creswell and Poth (2018) describe qualitative research as an approach for exploring and understanding the meaning individuals or groups ascribe to a social or human problem, and phenomenology as the design that examines the common meaning several individuals attach to their lived experience of a phenomenon. Van Manen (2016) characterizes lived experience as experience as it is lived and understood by the person before it is theorized or explained. In this study, the phenomenon was the professional encounter with adolescent gaming: how psychologists meet, interpret, and respond to it in their practice, rather than the adolescent's own first-person experience of well-being.

The design fit the study because its three research questions asked for meanings rather than measurements: how psychologists encounter and interpret adolescent gaming, which factors they consider, and how they describe the benefits and concerns, challenges, and strategies in their practice. The study did not measure variables, test hypotheses, or establish causal relationships. Its phenomenological focus was carried by the instrument itself: the interview guide supplied working definitions of adolescents, gaming, and gaming environments but deliberately left adolescent digital well-being undefined, so that the meaning of the study's central concept came from the participants' own accounts.

The study took an interpretive rather than a strictly descriptive approach to phenomenology. Accounts were analyzed through Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis, which identifies patterns of meaning across participants, and the researchers documented their

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assumptions and interpretive choices rather than claiming to set them aside completely. The bioecological model of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) informed interpretation after initial coding without determining the themes in advance.

Philosophical Underpinning

The philosophical assumption that primarily guided this study was epistemological. Creswell and Poth (2018) explain that the epistemological assumption concerns what counts as knowledge, how knowledge claims are justified, and the relationship between the researcher and the persons studied; under it, researchers reduce the distance between themselves and their participants and build knowledge from the participants' subjective accounts. Proceeding from this assumption, the researchers adopted an interpretivist stance. Knowledge about adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments was treated not as a fixed property waiting to be measured but as something constructed as psychologists observe, interpret, and respond to particular cases. Lincoln and Guba (1985) describe this position through naturalistic inquiry, in which realities are multiple and constructed and findings emerge from the interaction between inquirer and participant. The stance fits a study in which adolescent digital well-being, an experiential state belonging to the adolescent, could be reached only through the professional interpretations that psychologists give of it.

This stance shaped the study in four ways. First, participants were approached as knowers rather than as sources of measurable variables, which is why open-ended instruments rather than scales were used and why the central concept was left for participants to define. Second, because meaning is produced within the research encounter, the researchers used semi-structured interviews that allowed participants to elaborate, qualify, and give examples, and they asked for cases that complicated the participants' usual views. Third, the researchers' familiarity with

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gaming and with Filipino and Kapampangan contexts was treated as a resource for recognizing meanings, balanced by reflexivity because it could also shape expectations (see the Reflexivity section of Chapter 4). Fourth, the study made no claim to causal explanation or statistical generalization; its findings were evaluated against the trustworthiness criteria of Lincoln and Guba (1985).

Participants and Setting

The setting was Luzon, defined by the communities in which the participants practice or which they professionally serve. The study was first planned for Pampanga; during data collection, the setting was widened to Luzon so that eligible psychologists practicing outside the province could take part. The setting was not a single physical location but the participants' professional practice contexts, which included university guidance and counseling offices, private clinics, a hospital, local government and school-based services, and academic institutions.

Participants were selected through purposive sampling, which deliberately selects individuals with information-rich experience of the phenomenon rather than aiming for statistical representativeness (Creswell & Poth, 2018). To be eligible, a participant had to (a) hold a valid PRC license as a psychologist (RPsy), (b) have professional experience with adolescents of junior or senior high school age, and (c) practice in or serve a community in Luzon. The original criteria limited participation to clinical and counseling psychologists; the revised criteria admitted licensed psychologists from any field, because the professional encounter with adolescents, not the specialty label, was the experience the study required. A psychometrician license alone did not meet the criteria.

The original plan called for ten participants, and the revised plan set a target of five interviews supplemented by written questionnaires. Seven licensed psychologists took part: five

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were interviewed and two answered the written questionnaire. Table 1 presents their profile. Five practice in Pampanga, one in Metro Manila and Bulacan, and one in Nueva Ecija. Four described clinical psychology as their main field, one counseling psychology, one school or guidance work, and one academic teaching combined with clinical practice. Their years as licensed psychologists ranged from less than three to more than ten. Small samples are common in phenomenological research, which prioritizes the depth of individual accounts over breadth (Creswell & Poth, 2018); the limits of this sample are discussed in Chapter 4.

Table 1*Profile of the Participants*

Participant	Mode of participation	Main field of practice	Years as licensed psychologist	Location of practice
Interviewee 1	Interview (video call)	School or guidance	3 to 5	Pampanga
Interviewee 2	Interview (video call)	Counseling psychology	Less than 3	Metro Manila and Bulacan
Interviewee 3	Interview (video call)	Clinical psychology	Less than 3	Pampanga
Interviewee 4	Interview (face to face)	Clinical psychology	3 to 5	Pampanga
Interviewee 5	Interview (face to face)	Academe, with clinical practice	Less than 3	Pampanga
Interviewee 6	Written questionnaire	Clinical psychology	More than 10	Pampanga
Interviewee 7	Written questionnaire	Clinical psychology	7 to 10	Nueva Ecija

Note. Fields and years are as reported by the participants. Institutions and specific settings are omitted to protect anonymity.

Instrumentation

The primary instrument was a researcher-developed semi-structured interview guide. Semi-structured interviewing combines common topics with opportunities for participants to

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elaborate and for the interviewer to clarify meaning through follow-up questions and probes (Ruslin et al., 2022), and it suits phenomenological work because it lets participants discuss specific aspects of their experience while the interviewer adapts to what emerges (Henriksen et al., 2022). A structured interview would have limited the elaboration on which a phenomenological account depends, while an unstructured interview would have made consistent coverage of the research questions uncertain.

The guide opened with two preliminary questions on the participant's professional background and work with adolescents, followed by sixteen main questions arranged in three clusters that correspond to the three specific research questions, and a closing question. Items 1a to 1e asked how gaming comes up in practice, about a professional experience in which an adolescent's gaming became relevant, what the participant noticed when interpreting that case, how they understand adolescent digital well-being in relation to gaming, and how that understanding has changed. Items 2a to 2e asked which factors the participant considers, how they decide which matter most, how the factors relate to one another, whether their importance varies across adolescents and situations, and about an experience the usual factors did not explain. Items 3a to 3f asked about observed benefits, encountered concerns, cases with both, challenges in responding, useful strategies, and circumstances that support adolescents' digital well-being. The closing question invited participants to raise anything important that the interview had not covered. Probes were used to clarify answers and to invite concrete cases. The guide is presented in Appendix A.

Because some eligible psychologists could not schedule a live interview, the guide was also prepared as an open-ended online questionnaire (Appendix B). It contained the same items, preceded by eligibility and profile questions, and it allowed respondents to state that an experience

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had not occurred. It used no rating scales and produced no numerical scores, so the addition of written responses did not make the study a mixed-methods design. Written responses offered no opportunity for live probing, a limitation considered during analysis.

Before data collection, the interview guide was validated for relevance, appropriateness, clarity, and alignment with the objectives of the study. Validators rated the guide on a five-point agreement scale across five criteria, for a total of 25 points: whether the questions address the specific research questions; whether they are open-ended, non-leading, and free of double-barreled phrasing; whether their language suits the respondents; whether they follow a smooth sequence from general to deeper topics; and whether the information sheet, consent form, and interview schedule are complete. The research adviser and the subject teacher also reviewed the guide, and revisions were made based on the validators' ratings and comments before it was administered.

The guide was accompanied by an information sheet and an informed consent form, which stated the purpose of the study, the procedure, the expected duration, the voluntary nature of participation, confidentiality, and data handling, and which supplied the working definitions of adolescents, gaming, gaming environments, and lived professional experience.

Data Collection***Before Data Collection***

With the approval of the research adviser, the researchers invited prospective participants and confirmed their eligibility (license, professional experience with adolescents, and practice in Luzon) before participation. Invitations described the study without asking for a favorable or unfavorable view of gaming. Each prospective participant received the information sheet and consent form in advance, and interviews were scheduled at a date, time, and mode convenient to the participant.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***During Data Collection***

The five interviews were conducted between September 13 and September 21, 2026: three by video call and two face to face. Each session opened with a restatement of the study's purpose, the voluntary nature of participation, and the participant's right to decline any question, pause the recording, or stop. Permission to record was confirmed before recording began. Several researchers took turns asking the questions in each session. Participants could answer in English, Filipino, or Kapampangan, and they answered in English and Filipino, often mixing the two. Participants were asked to describe cases in general terms and to leave out client names and identifying details. Based on the recordings, the interviews lasted approximately 40 to 55 minutes. The two written questionnaires were completed on September 18 and October 5, 2026; respondents answered independently and could leave items blank, and no follow-up questions were sent.

After Data Collection

Recordings, transcripts, and consent forms were kept in the research team's cloud folder. Each interview was transcribed verbatim into a master transcript, with Filipino and English passages kept as spoken. Where a manual transcript was incomplete, gaps were filled with automatic transcriptions, and the source of each passage was tagged. A member of the research team checked the master transcripts of Interviewees 2 to 5 against the recordings and resolved unclear passages. The master transcript of Interviewee 1 was completed from a video transcription, and part of it has no timestamps. Written responses were kept exactly as submitted. Names of participants, clients, and institutions were removed and replaced with participant codes. Recordings and other identifiable files will be deleted no later than four weeks after the final submission of the study.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Data Analysis**

The data were analyzed using the six phases of thematic analysis described by Braun and Clarke (2006), a method for identifying, analyzing, and reporting patterns of meaning across a data set. Thematic analysis suited this study because it offers a structured but flexible way to capture professional meanings without imposing a predetermined coding scheme, which mattered because the instrument left the study's central concept undefined. The analysis was recorded in a coding workbook that linked every extract to its participant, mode, location in the recording or questionnaire, language, English gloss, code, theme, and research question.

Phase 1: Familiarizing With the Data

The researchers read and reread the master transcripts and written responses, compared quoted passages with their sources, and noted context, possible meanings, and questions. Divergent views and accounts in which the phenomenon had not been encountered were noted from the start.

Phase 2: Generating Initial Codes

Relevant phrases, sentences, or passages were divided into extracts, one meaning per extract, and assigned codes grounded in the participants' own words. Answers given under one question but belonging to another were coded where their content belonged. A total of 203 extracts were coded with 86 initial codes. Each code was also tagged with the PPCT element it related to, but this tag was added after the code was formed, so that the framework organized the codes rather than generated them.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***Phase 3: Searching for Themes***

Related codes were grouped into candidate themes for each research question. Under the third research question, the candidate themes were separated into benefits and concerns, challenges, and strategies, so that each part of the question was represented distinctly.

Phase 4: Reviewing Themes

Candidate themes were checked against their extracts and against the whole data set, and they were refined, separated, or merged when their central idea was unclear. For example, “Function over frequency” was kept separate from “Well-being as balance and control” because the first describes how psychologists read gaming and the second how they define well-being. Accounts that contradicted a theme were retained and logged as negative cases; twelve were recorded (Appendix D). One extract that described the psychologist’s own self-care rather than work with adolescents was left unassigned.

Phase 5: Defining and Naming Themes

Each theme was given a definition stating its meaning and boundaries and a plain name, using participants’ own phrases where possible. The final structure consisted of fifteen themes, four for the first research question, five for the second, and six for the third, which together contain 202 of the 203 extracts. The codes and their themes are listed in Appendix C.

Phase 6: Writing Up

The themes were written up with direct quotations as evidence, each attributed to the participant and to the time in the recording or the questionnaire item. Statements in Filipino were kept as spoken and followed by English translations. Each theme was then related to the literature reviewed in Chapter 1 and interpreted through the bioecological model.

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Two kinds of software assisted the analysis. Automatic transcription tools (Gemini and Whisper) were used to fill gaps in incomplete manual transcripts, as described above, and a generative AI tool (Claude) was used to draft initial codes, English glosses, and candidate themes in the coding workbook from the master transcripts. The researchers checked these drafts against the transcripts and recordings and made the final decisions on the themes, their names, and the quotations used, and these decisions were recorded in the audit trail (Anthropic, 2026; Google, 2026; OpenAI, 2022).

Establishing Trustworthiness

The rigor of the study was established through the four criteria of trustworthiness proposed by Lincoln and Guba (1985): credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability.

Credibility

Credibility concerns how accurately the findings represent the participants' experiences, and it was supported in four ways. The semi-structured interviews allowed the researchers to probe and clarify answers during each session. Quoted passages were traced to their location in the recording or questionnaire, and four of the five interview transcripts were checked against the recordings. Accounts that did not fit the emerging themes were sought out and reported as negative cases rather than set aside. Finally, the findings present the participants' own words with translations, so that readers can weigh each interpretation against the evidence. Written responses, which allowed no follow-up, were used mainly to support themes rather than to build them.

Transferability

Transferability concerns the extent to which the findings may be meaningful in other settings, and it was supported through thick description. The participants' profile (Table 1), their practice settings, the modes of participation, and the depth of each account are reported so that



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readers can judge how far the findings may apply elsewhere. The concentration of the sample in Pampanga is stated wherever it matters.

Dependability

Dependability concerns the consistency of the research process, and it was maintained through an audit trail. The coding workbook kept dated records of transcription decisions, coding rules, theme development, negative cases, and changes to the analysis, together with the interview guide and its written version, so that the process can be followed by the research adviser or another researcher.

Confirmability

Confirmability concerns the degree to which the findings are grounded in the data rather than in researcher bias. It was supported by generating codes from the participants' words before applying the framework, by reporting negative cases and divergent views, and by reflexivity. The researchers' assumptions, including their own experience with gaming and the possibility of favoring accounts that defend it, are stated in the Reflexivity section of Chapter 4.

Ethical Considerations

Participation was voluntary. Before taking part, each participant received the information sheet and gave informed consent, and interview participants confirmed their permission to be recorded before recording began. Participants were informed that they could decline any question, ask that the recording be paused or stopped, or withdraw at any time without penalty. No payment was given for participation.

Because the participants are licensed professionals discussing their practice, particular care was taken with confidentiality. Participants were identified only by code (Interviewee 1 to Interviewee 7), and the names of participants, clients, and institutions were removed from the

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transcripts and from this report. Participants were asked to describe cases in general terms and to omit details that could identify a client, consistent with their own professional obligations. Because anonymity is harder to protect in a small professional community, the researchers also reviewed quotations and participant descriptions for details that could identify someone indirectly; for this reason, Table 1 reports fields and locations but not institutions, and participants are referred to with they/them pronouns in the findings.

Personal data were handled in accordance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012 (Republic Act No. 10173, 2012). The study did not diagnose or assess any adolescent, family, or participant, and participants' views about the causes of conditions such as neurodivergence, aggression, or gaming disorder are reported as their professional views and are not presented as established findings. The risk to participants was minimal, since the questions concerned their professional practice rather than their personal lives and did not evaluate their competence. The expected benefit is a practitioner-informed account that may serve as reference material for school-based mental health services.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Chapter 3****Findings**

This chapter presents the themes developed from the accounts of seven PRC-licensed psychologists practicing in or serving communities in Luzon. Five participated through semi-structured interviews, held by video call or face to face, while two responded to the open-ended written questionnaire. The data were analyzed using the six phases of thematic analysis described by Braun and Clarke (2006). A total of 203 extracts were coded using 86 initial codes. Of these, 202 extracts were incorporated into the 15 final themes, while one extract concerning a psychologist's own self-care rather than professional work with adolescents was not assigned to a theme.

The themes are presented by statement of the problem: four themes for SOP 1, five for SOP 2, and six for SOP 3, where SOP 3 is divided into benefits and concerns, challenges, and strategies (Table 2). Each theme is first explained, then supported by extracts from the participants, and then related to the literature and studies reviewed in Chapter 1 and to the bioecological framework. Where a participant's account differed from the others, the difference is reported within the theme.

Participants are identified as Interviewee 1 to Interviewee 7 and, to protect their anonymity, are referred to with they/them pronouns. Interviewees 1 to 5 were interviewed, and each of their extracts is followed by the time in the recording where the passage begins; several passages from Interviewee 1 come from a part of the transcript without timestamps and are cited by interview question instead. Interviewees 6 and 7 answered in writing, so the questionnaire item is given. Statements spoken in Filipino or in a mix of Filipino and English are presented as spoken, followed by an English translation in brackets. Pauses are omitted, breaks in speech are shown with ellipses, and words left out of a long passage are marked with [...].

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The participant counts in Table 2 show how widely each theme was discussed, not how many participants agreed with it, because a theme's count also includes participants whose accounts went against it. The counts describe this data set only and are not measures of prevalence.

Table 2

Themes by Statement of the Problem

SOP	Theme	Participants (of 7)	Extracts
1	1.1 Gaming Surfaces Behind Other Concerns	6	13
	1.2 Function Over Frequency	4	18
	1.3 Well-Being as Balance and Control, Not the Absence of Gaming	5	8
	1.4 From Judging the Game to Understanding the Gamer	5	13
2	2.1 The Adolescent's Emotional State, Motives, and Basic Needs	6	13
	2.2 The Family as a Source of Stress and of Support	4	5
	2.3 Online Peers as Belonging and as Risk	3	6
	2.4 The Game's Content, Cost, and Public Image	4	10
	2.5 Interlocking Factors Whose Weight Differs per Adolescent	7	24
3(a)	3.1 Relief, Connection, and Skills	7	13
	3.2 Gaming That Disrupts Daily Functioning	7	19
	3.3 Benefits and Concerns in the Same Adolescent	7	13
3(b)	3.4 Resistant Parents and the Adolescent's Own Commitment	7	13
3(c)	3.5 Understanding the Adolescent Before Acting on the Gaming	7	20
	3.6 Gradual Regulation, Offline Alternatives, and Psychoeducation	6	14
Total			202

Note. Participant counts include divergent and negative-case accounts within each theme. One further extract (practitioner self-care) was not assigned to a theme, for a total of 203 coded extracts.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Themes for SOP 1**

How do psychologists in Luzon describe their lived professional experiences of encountering and interpreting adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?

Four themes describe how the psychologists encountered and interpreted adolescent gaming in their practice: where gaming appeared in their work, how they read its meaning, how they defined digital well-being, and how their understanding had changed over time.

Theme 1.1: Gaming Surfaces Behind Other Concerns

Six of the seven psychologists said that gaming seldom arrived as the reason an adolescent was referred to them. It came up instead when they asked about the adolescent's sleep, school attendance, mood, daily routine, hobbies, or relationships (Interviewee 1, 05:04; Interviewee 5, 05:30), or when parents brought a child after school refusal or aggression at home. Interviewee 3 had handled a case centered on gaming "once or twice" (06:25), Interviewee 4 "two or three" times (15:43), and Interviewee 6 reported "few instances" (written response, item 1a). Interviewee 7 wrote that gaming usually came up "when they talk about their hobbies" (written response, item 1a), and Interviewee 3 added that doomscrolling on social media, rather than gaming, was the more frequent digital concern in that practice (40:45). Adolescents brought by their parents were often described as ashamed and slow to open up, which kept the gaming out of view in the first sessions. Interviewee 4 went further than the others and connected the gaming and screen use uncovered in such cases to the development of neurodivergence and relationship problems, a view presented as the participant's own clinical interpretation. The following extracts show how gaming entered the psychologists' work.

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“most of the time it’s not the main thing, eh, the gaming itself; it’s more of the dysfunction behind it. So they see to it na, or they share things like they have difficulty focusing sa studies nila, or they have sleeping problems, or ’yung iba hindi na rin nakakakain. So there’s that dysfunctional part. And when I ask about his environment, about their day-to-day activities, most of the time they would mention, ’yun nga, gaming pala is a huge chunk of it”

[Most of the time, the gaming itself is not the main thing; it is more the dysfunction behind it. They share things like having difficulty focusing on their studies, having sleeping problems, or, for some, no longer being able to eat. So there is that dysfunctional part. And when I ask about their environment and their day-to-day activities, most of the time they mention that, as it turns out, gaming is a huge chunk of it.] (Interviewee 3, 08:01)

“I met high school students, very young high school students, like Grade 7, Grade 8, na ayaw nang pumasok, noh? Kasi gusto na lang nila nasa bahay, tapos naga-games. [...] Pero I saw that, with my own two eyes, na ’yung mga batang ’to, kapag kinuha ng parent ’yung gadget, talagang nagiging aggressive. So there was a narrative from a parent, which I heard, na she tried to get the gadget, the iPad, of her child, kinuha ng bata ’yung Red Horse na bote at would throw it at the parent.”

[I met high school students, very young high school students in Grade 7 and Grade 8, who no longer wanted to go to school because they just wanted to stay home and play games. [...] But I saw it with my own two eyes: when the parent took the gadget away, these children really became aggressive. There was a story from a parent, which I heard myself, that when she tried to take her child’s gadget, an iPad, the child picked up a Red Horse bottle and was about to throw it at her.] (Interviewee 5, 08:38)

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“I notice na there’s that behavioral change sa kanila. And most of them feel ashamed, ano, kasi nakita ko, they’re not confident or proud of what they’ve done kasi nga naapektuhan na ’yung buhay nila sa pamilya nila, ’yung buhay nila sa school, so I see that emotion, shame. And ’yun nga, uh, siguro, difficulty opening up, kasi nga they’re not too confident of what they’ve done. But I see na in their own way, they’re trying to open, they’re trying to cope.”

[I notice that there is a behavioral change in them. And most of them feel ashamed, because I can see that they are not confident or proud of what they have done, since it has already affected their life with their family and their life in school. So I see that emotion, shame. And so, perhaps, there is difficulty opening up, because they are not very confident about what they have done. But I see that in their own way, they are trying to open up; they are trying to cope.]
(Interviewee 3, 09:28)

“Usually in the cases that I’ve had hindi ’yung gaming ang main concern niya. It’s usually ’yung presenting problem nila, it’s usually ’yung mood problem nila like ’yung bipolar or depression or ’yung neurodivergence nila or ’yung kagaya nung isang adult ’yung relationships niya. [...] But when you dig deeper, you get to connect na baka isang factor ’yun kung bakit siya, ’yung gaming and screen use niya that led to gaming addiction, isa ’yun sa mga risk factors niya for developing neurodivergence or relationship problems. So gaming and screen use are considered risk factors.”

[Usually, in the cases I have had, gaming is not the client’s main concern. The presenting problem is usually a mood problem, such as bipolar disorder or depression, or their neurodivergence, or, as with one adult client, relationships. [...] But when you dig deeper, you come to connect that it may be one factor: their gaming and screen use, which led to gaming addiction, is one of their risk factors for developing neurodivergence or relationship problems. So gaming and screen use are considered risk factors.] (Interviewee 4, 31:12)

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This pattern is consistent with the review's position that gaming outcomes cannot be read from exposure alone. Gaming did not present itself as a diagnosis; it surfaced through its effects on functioning, which is the same line that the literature uses to separate problematic gaming from enthusiastic play (Columb et al., 2022; King & Delfabbro, 2019). It also echoes the practitioners in Lo et al. (2021), who treated adolescent internet problems as heterogeneous cases to be understood within the adolescent's relationships rather than as a single behavior. The shame and reluctance described by Interviewee 3 add a point the reviewed studies did not address: when adolescents are brought in by their parents, the gaming may stay hidden until trust is built, which is why the psychologists found it by asking about daily life rather than about gaming. In bioecological terms, the psychologists entered the configuration through the Person (mood, sleep, and functioning) and the microsystem (the family's complaint) before they reached the gaming itself (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007).

Interviewee 4's account goes further than the reviewed literature. The studies reviewed in Chapter 1 report associations between gaming and outcomes such as depressive symptoms rather than causes (Labana et al., 2020), so the view that screen use is a risk factor for developing neurodivergence is reported here as the participant's clinical interpretation. Interviewee 3's remark that doomscrolling troubles clients more than gaming also marks a limit of the study's focus on gaming, which is taken up in the recommendations.

Theme 1.2: Function Over Frequency

Rather than counting hours of play, four of the psychologists asked what gaming did for the adolescent. They described gaming as an escape from overwhelming schoolwork or family stress, a way to cope, a cathartic release (Interviewee 2, 09:07), and, for one student, a way to remember a late father. Interviewee 1 stated the stance directly: two adolescents "can spend the same amount of



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time playing games, but they experience different outcomes” (11:57), so the purpose of play matters more than its frequency, and the participant assessed that purpose by asking what the adolescent gets from playing and what happens when the adolescent cannot play. Interviewee 2 also read gaming as a signal: a student who had added the participant on a gaming platform would play simulator games when overwhelmed, and the platform’s notifications became an opening for a counseling conversation (15:33). Interviewee 5 explained that some adolescents use games to delay difficult tasks, which the participant framed as a problem of emotional regulation rather than laziness. Interviewee 7 likewise wrote that some adolescents find gaming a safe space while others play to cope with their problems. The following extracts illustrate this way of reading gaming.

“one thing I have learned to consider or to notice is that we need to look at the function rather than just the frequency of their gaming. [...] I would usually ask my client, ‘Why are you playing?’ ‘What do you get from it?’ ‘And what happens when you stopped playing?’ ‘What happens when you can’t play?’”
(Interviewee 1, 07:30)

“some of them kasi... it’s a shared memory with their loved ones. I met a student back then na naglalaro siya ng gaming, naglalaro siya because that’s how he remembers his late father.”

[For some of them, it is a shared memory with their loved ones. I once met a student who played games because that is how he remembers his late father.]
(Interviewee 2, 13:20)

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“we define procrastination as an emotional problem, rather than what we believe... okay, originally, we see procrastination as a form of laziness, eh, noh. Pero we have a certain subject here where we teach that procrastination is an emotional regulation problem. Ayaw mong harapin kasi mahirap, masakit, o kaya perfectionist ka, ayaw mong umpisahan, natatakot kang mag-fail, ganyan-ganyan. So one way to procrastinate is to play games, right? Kasi immediate pleasure ’yung binibigay ng games, so we are wired to seek pleasure and to avoid pain.”

[We define procrastination as an emotional problem rather than what we usually believe. Originally, we see procrastination as a form of laziness. But we have a subject here where we teach that procrastination is an emotional regulation problem. You do not want to face the task because it is hard or painful, or because you are a perfectionist and do not want to start, or because you are afraid to fail, things like that. So one way to procrastinate is to play games, right? Because games give immediate pleasure, and we are wired to seek pleasure and to avoid pain.] (Interviewee 5, 11:07)

“Some find it to be their safe space, others play games to cope with their problems” (Interviewee 7, written response, item 1d)

Reading gaming by its function rather than its frequency is the practice-level form of the definition of digital well-being adopted in Chapter 1. Vanden Abeele (2021) describes digital well-being as a dynamic balance shaped by a person’s coping, social environment, and situation rather than by a fixed amount of use, and Dienlin and Johannes (2020) argue that the effects of digital technology depend on how and why it is used. The functions the psychologists named also match the review’s description of gaming environments: Giardina et al. (2024) describe games as spaces that may offer relief, escape, or connection, and Uçur and Dönmez (2021) found that adolescents with weaker emotional regulation may turn to games to escape difficult emotions, the same mechanism Interviewee 5 described in framing gaming-as-procrastination as a regulation problem.

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Encallado et al. (2024) reported the same functions, enjoyment, social connection, and stress relief, in the accounts of Filipino senior high school gamers. Within the PPCT model, this theme concerns the Process component: the same recurring interaction with a game carries a different developmental meaning depending on what it does for the person (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007).

Not every participant shared this reading. Interviewee 4 located the harm in screen exposure itself, whatever its function, a view presented under Theme 1.3.

Theme 1.3: Well-Being as Balance and Control, Not the Absence of Gaming

When asked how they understand adolescent digital well-being in relation to gaming, five participants defined it as the ability to game in a balanced and controlled way that leaves daily life intact, not as the absence of gaming. Interviewee 5 put the definition in both directions: gaming does not make an adolescent unwell, and not gaming does not make an adolescent well. Well-being was considered lost when gaming disrupted sleep, school, relationships, or self-care, and Interviewee 5 named adequate sleep as its most basic requirement. Interviewee 1 placed the line at control: gaming is “not automatically dangerous or harmful,” and what matters “is whether they are able to maintain control over it” (09:30). Interviewee 6 wrote that well-being means “balancing enjoyment and responsible use” (written response, item 1d). Interviewee 2 went further in the positive direction, describing gaming as a lifeline for some students for whom other recommendations, such as exercise, had not worked. Interviewee 4 held a different view, arguing that long periods of passive screen use, “even with wholesome content” (09:56), condition the developing brain to become passive and weaken the ability to be intentional and mindful. The following extracts present these understandings.



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“digital well-being is not the complete absence of gaming. Hindi ibig sabihin na nagga-game ka, hindi ka na well. Hindi rin ibig sabihin na hindi ka nagga-game, well ka.”

[Digital well-being is not the complete absence of gaming. Just because you play games does not mean that you are not well. Likewise, not playing games does not necessarily mean that you are well.] (Interviewee 5, 13:23)

“it’s the ability to engage with gaming in a way that supports or serves you. Ano ba ang function ng gaming sa buhay mo? Ideally, it does not significantly interfere with your functioning. In psychology, one criterion for saying that a person has a disorder is when that particular behavior is already making the person dysfunctional. So ‘yung gaming ba, ano ba ‘yung effect niya sa’yo? Nagiging dysfunctional ka ba? [...] pag hindi ka na natutulog dahil sa game, hindi ka na well, kasi ang basic requirement of well-being is adequate sleep.”

[It is the ability to engage with gaming in a way that supports or serves you. What is the function of gaming in your life? Ideally, it does not significantly interfere with your functioning. In psychology, one criterion for saying that a person has a disorder is when that behavior is already making the person dysfunctional. So, with gaming, what is its effect on you? Are you becoming dysfunctional? [...] If you no longer sleep because of a game, you are no longer well, because the basic requirement of well-being is adequate sleep.] (Interviewee 5, 13:23)

“’yun yung parang lifeline nila. Most of the nao-observe ko, with some of my clients also, uh, I observe ‘yun yung nagiging lifeline nila. May mga students ako kasi na instead of suggesting them na exercise, sometimes kasi it does not work for them. What works for them is gaming talaga.”

[It is like their lifeline. In most of what I have observed, including with some of my clients, it becomes their lifeline. I have students for whom suggesting exercise sometimes does not work. What really works for them is gaming.] (Interviewee 2, 15:33)

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“There’s ’yung tinatawag na brain plasticity. Whatever you let your brain experience, consume. Parang it conditions your brain to be like that. So ’yung passive consumer ka lang, nagiging passive din ’yung brain mo. To a point where you cannot, parang you lose the ability to be intentional, to solve problems, to be mindful.”

[There is what we call brain plasticity. Whatever you let your brain experience and consume conditions your brain to be like that. So if you are only a passive consumer, your brain also becomes passive, to the point where you lose the ability to be intentional, to solve problems, and to be mindful.] (Interviewee 4, 10:03)

The majority view corresponds closely with the definitions reviewed in Chapter 1. Feerrar (2022) describes digital well-being as the capacity to maintain physical, emotional, and social health while using technology, and Vanden Abeele (2021) frames it as a dynamic equilibrium rather than a matter of screen time; the participants’ emphasis on balance, control, and intact functioning restates both definitions in clinical terms. Interviewee 5’s use of dysfunction as the threshold also mirrors how gaming disorder is defined, by impaired control and significant impairment in functioning rather than by hours of play (Király et al., 2022; WHO, 2020), and it reflects the difficulty Columb et al. (2022) describe of telling enthusiastic gaming apart from disordered gaming. Interviewee 2’s description of gaming as a lifeline gives the positive side of the same balance, consistent with Nagata et al. (2026), who note that games can offer real health benefits when play is driven by genuine interest and paired with self-regulation.

Interviewee 4’s position is the main divergent account in this theme. It locates risk in the developing brain and in the amount of passive exposure rather than in function, and it was kept as a distinct clinical view rather than reinterpreted to fit the majority. The reviewed literature does not settle this disagreement: Dahl et al. (2018) describe adolescence as a period in which

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developmental trajectories can shift in either direction, which is compatible with the participant's concern, while the studies reviewed report associations rather than the causal effect the account implies.

Theme 1.4: From Judging the Game to Understanding the Gamer

Five participants described how their understanding of adolescent gaming had changed over the course of their practice, and four of them described the same direction of change. Earlier in their careers they tended to see gaming as a problem or as a sign of irresponsibility; with experience they began to look at its context and meaning. They gave three reasons for the change. The first was a developmental view of adolescents as still maturing. The second was an awareness of the generational gap in what gaming means: Interviewee 1 recalled that gaming used to be a luxury limited to internet shops and prepaid load, whereas it is now an everyday way of connecting with people (13:58). The third was the growing social acceptance of gaming: Interviewee 2, who had played games as an adolescent, observed that gamers are no longer laughed at or bullied as they once were (17:50), and Interviewee 5 said that meeting students in e-sports had shown that gaming could be a student's strength and a source of confidence (16:06). Interviewee 4 moved the other way: concern about screen use grew after the pandemic, when the participant saw more mental health cases among young people and formed the hypothesis, partly from observing their own children, that the length of screen time affects mental health (06:52). Interviewee 5 closed the interview by stating the change as a goal for practice: not simply to reduce gaming, but to understand the gamer.

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“I’ve always seen gaming as a problem for young people. ‘Yung typical na ‘Boomer-Millennial’ mindset noh na pag kasi gaming parang ‘ay,’ it’s something negative; it’s something that could affect their responsibilities in school and at home. Eh, I paid more attention to their screen time, how long they’re doing it, and so on. But with the experience that I have gained in the past years, I started to become more interested in the context of gaming and what its function is.”

[I have always seen gaming as a problem for young people, the typical ‘Boomer-Millennial’ mindset where, when it comes to gaming, it is ‘oh,’ something negative, something that could affect their responsibilities in school and at home. So I paid more attention to their screen time, how long they were doing it, and so on. But with the experience I have gained in the past years, I started to become more interested in the context of gaming and what its function is.]
(Interviewee 1, 11:57)

“Kasi, I wouldn’t ask na parang, anong mali sa kanila or bakit nila ginagawa ‘yun, kasi in hindsight I already know why. It’s part of them developing. Kumbaga, they themselves kasi, they’re not the finished product.”

[Because I would not ask what is wrong with them or why they do it, since in hindsight I already know why. It is part of their development. In a way, they themselves are not yet the finished product.] (Interviewee 3, 11:58)

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“there were a surge in the cases on mental health conditions after the pandemic. Largely because of the environment that we were forced to live in during the pandemic, no? We were isolated. And I think that has greatly affected young people even more because of the fact that young people’s brains are still developing. So kung kami na medyo matanda na, adult na by that time, na-experience namin ’yung dysregulation because of the very unnatural environment that you have to be digital online for an extended period of time.”

[There was a surge in cases of mental health conditions after the pandemic, largely because of the environment we were forced to live in during the pandemic. We were isolated. And I think that affected young people even more, because young people’s brains are still developing. So if we, who were already somewhat older and already adults at that time, experienced dysregulation because of the very unnatural environment of having to be digital and online for an extended period of time...] (Interviewee 4, 04:44)

“That gaming should not be viewed only as a behavior that adults must control. Kasi ’yun ang tingin natin, parati, ’yung gaming, ang goal natin diyan, palagi, kontrolin lang. There’s something beyond that. Pwede kasi maging useful ang gaming para maintindihan, ano ba ang kailangan ng mga adolescents? Bakit sila andon? Kasi baka makaisip tayo ng ibang paraan besides gaming na ma-meet mo ’yung needs nila. So it could be a door to understanding the needs of adolescents. The goal is not to simply reduce gaming, but to understand the gamer.”

[Gaming should not be viewed only as a behavior that adults must control. That is how we always see it: with gaming, our goal is always just to control it. There is something beyond that. Gaming can be useful for understanding what adolescents need. Why are they there? Because then we might think of other ways besides gaming to meet their needs. So it could be a door to understanding the needs of adolescents. The goal is not to simply reduce gaming, but to understand the gamer.] (Interviewee 5, 49:26)

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The direction of this change parallels a movement in the literature itself. UNICEF Office of Research – Innocenti (2022) and Meriläinen et al. (2023) observe that research on young people’s digital lives has been largely concern-centric, focused on harms more than on the conditions under which gaming supports development, and the participants described moving from a similar concern-centric reading toward a contextual one. The developmental reasoning offered by Interviewee 3 echoes Dahl et al. (2018), who describe adolescence as a period of learning and adaptation in which developmental trajectories are still forming. The attention to changing meanings across generations and to gaming’s growing acceptance corresponds to the Time component of the PPCT model, which recognizes that the same activity takes on different meanings in different historical periods (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007).

Interviewee 4’s account shows that the Time component can also move judgment in the opposite direction. For this participant, the historical event that mattered was the pandemic, associated with a rise in mental health cases and a stronger concern about screens. The two directions therefore share a recognition that professional judgment is shaped by the period in which it is made, even though they reach different conclusions.

Themes for SOP 2

How do psychologists in Luzon describe the factors that shape adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?

Five themes describe the factors that the psychologists considered when judging how gaming relates to an adolescent’s digital well-being. They are arranged from the factors closest to the adolescent to the wider setting, and they end with how these factors relate to one another.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY***Theme 2.1: The Adolescent's Emotional State, Motives, and Basic Needs***

The first factors the psychologists checked were within the adolescent: the emotional state before, during, and after playing, the stressor the adolescent might be avoiding, the motive for playing, the pattern and amount of play, and the adolescent's clinical history. Interviewee 1 listed the motives the participant distinguishes, recreation, social connection, competition, achievement, and escape, and described tracing "what happens before they do gaming, what do they experience while they're gaming, and then what happens afterwards" (20:38). Interviewee 5 asked who the adolescent becomes after playing. Interviewee 3 began, as a matter of protocol, with the adolescent's medical history, including any history of emotional abuse or family conflict (13:23), and Interviewee 4 noted that exposure to gaming shapes how adolescents learn to spend time, de-stress, and cope (37:08). Interviewee 7 wrote of considering the "frequency, intensity, and duration of use" and "how it impacts their daily living" (written response, item 2a). When asked which factor mattered most, Interviewee 3 and Interviewee 5 both pointed to basic needs, namely whether the adolescent still slept, ate, and took care of themselves, and placed these before emotional factors. The following extracts present these factors.

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“Is it primarily recreational? Do they just want to relax? Or is it social? Baka, it’s their way of parang connecting with their friends kasi di niya nakikita or nakakausap friends niya, and through gaming they can connect. Is it competitive? Baka naman may ibang gains siyang nakukuha out of it, diba? Is it because they want to achieve something? Kasi gusto niya, ’pag natapos niya ’yung game na ’to achievement ’yon. So may finufulfill siya na need for achievement. Or is it being used to avoid something? Is it their way of escaping?”

[Is it primarily recreational? Do they just want to relax? Or is it social? Maybe it is their way of connecting with their friends, because they cannot see or talk to their friends, and through gaming they can connect. Is it competitive? Maybe they get other gains out of it, right? Is it because they want to achieve something? Because for them, finishing this game is an achievement, so they are fulfilling a need for achievement. Or is it being used to avoid something? Is it their way of escaping?] (Interviewee 1, 18:23)

“Next, uh, emotional state before and after gaming. After gaming, who are you as a person? Do you just end up hating yourself after gaming? Do you end up hating others after gaming?” (Interviewee 5, 18:11)

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“mas mawe-weigh ko na siyempre, ’yung physical well-being muna nila ’yung gusto kong tignan ’no. Kasi maraming cases na puro gano’n sa gaming industry addiction eh. May instance na hindi sila kumakain so. there’s malnutrition ’no. Tapos, ’yung mga sleep deprived, andaming problems, mood ’no, shifting ng mood, may behavioural problems, may aggression problems ’no. That follows nalang. Pero siyempre ’yung unang una is physically muna. ’Yun yung pinaka, followed by ’yung emotional well-being factors.”

[I would give more weight, of course, to their physical well-being first; that is what I want to look at. Because there are many cases like that in gaming addiction. There are instances where they do not eat, so there is malnutrition. Then those who are sleep deprived have many problems: mood, shifting moods, behavioral problems, aggression problems. Those just follow. But of course, the very first is the physical. That comes first, followed by the emotional well-being factors.] (Interviewee 3, 14:51)

“’yung pinaka-importante ’yung affected na ang basic physiological needs. Ano ’yung basic physiological needs? Sleep. Eating. ’Di na kumakain, ’di na natutulog. Okay, ’di ba, pinaka-importante ’yon? Wala ng ibang kaibigan sa labas. Ano yon, uh, belongingness needs ’yon. Number two siguro ’yung safety.”
[The most important is when the basic physiological needs are already affected. What are the basic physiological needs? Sleep. Eating. They no longer eat; they no longer sleep. That is the most important, isn’t it? They no longer have other friends outside; that is the need for belongingness. Number two, perhaps, is safety.] (Interviewee 5, 22:56)

These factors correspond to the Person component of the PPCT model, the adolescent’s characteristics, motives, and current state, which Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) describe as shaping how a recurring interaction affects development. The attention to emotional state and to the stressor behind play is consistent with Uçur and Dönmez (2021), who identified emotional dysregulation as a key predictor of problematic gaming among adolescents, and with Giardina et

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al. (2024), who describe gaming as a possible compensatory escape. Interviewee 1's before-during-after approach offers a practical way of distinguishing these functions in a single case. The priority given to sleep, food, and self-care matches the study by Encallado et al. (2024), in which Filipino senior high school gamers reported disrupted sleep and missed meals, and the findings of Yang et al. (2024), in which adequate sleep and physical activity were associated with lower nonacademic digital media use among adolescents in the United States. By ranking basic needs first, the psychologists treated the body as the first place where the balance described by Vanden Abeele (2021) is either kept or lost.

Theme 2.2: The Family as a Source of Stress and of Support

Four participants described the family both as a source of the stress that adolescents escape through gaming and as a source of protection. Interviewee 2 said that most of the triggers young people experience now come from the family unit itself, and Interviewee 5 asked adolescents which stressor they were avoiding, giving family arguments as an example. For some adolescents, gaming served as an escape from a toxic or abusive home or as a way to forget a trauma. At the same time, the psychologists checked family support and supervision as protective factors that could balance the risk: Interviewee 4 looked at whether the adolescent could draw support from the family and had friends, and Interviewee 1 named a supportive family, supportive friends, open communication, healthy sleep routines, and offline and physical activities as the circumstances that help (question 3f). The following extracts present both sides of the family's role.

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“malaking factor din ang family, kasi, ngayon ha, sa mga kabataan ngayon, most of the triggers, or, they are experiencing right now, comes from the family itself ’no. The family unit. Du’n sila nase-stress ’yun ’yung nagiging source ng trigger nila. The family unit talaga.”

[The family is also a big factor, because nowadays, among young people today, most of the triggers they are experiencing come from the family itself, the family unit. That is where they get stressed; that becomes the source of their triggers. The family unit, really.] (Interviewee 2, 23:11)

“ano ’yung stressor that you’re trying to avoid... that’s why you’re gaming. Ano ’yung stressor mo. Halimbawa, kapag nagkakaroon ng family arguments, ina-avoid mo ’yon, nas-stress ka kapag naririnig mo may mga family argument, nagge-gaming ka. So importante ano ’yung existing stressor that lead you to gaming. Kaya bumagsak ka sa quiz, magge-gaming ka.”

[What is the stressor that you are trying to avoid, which is why you are gaming? What is your stressor? For example, when there are family arguments, you avoid them; you get stressed when you hear family arguments, so you play games. So it is important to know the existing stressor that leads you to gaming. You failed a quiz, so you play games.] (Interviewee 5, 18:11)

“meron ding mga cases na ’yun pala ’yung ginagawa nila just for them to, you know, parang escape a very toxic or abusive environment. For some, it’s their way of trying to forget a trauma.”

[There are also cases where, it turns out, that is what they do just to escape a very toxic or abusive environment. For some, it is their way of trying to forget a trauma.] (Interviewee 1, 29:54)

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“di mo lang titignan ’yung risk niya, pati ’yung supports niya, like ’yung family environment niya. Okay ba ’yung environment niya sa family support? May support ba siyang pwedeng makuha sa family niya? May friends ba siya?”
[You do not only look at the risk but also at the supports, like the family environment. Is the family environment supportive? Is there support they can get from their family? Do they have friends?] (Interviewee 4, 50:09)

The two-sided role of the family matches the family-factor research reviewed in Chapter 1. Schneider et al. (2017) found that warm, cohesive family environments with positive parent-child relationships are associated with lower problematic gaming, while weak monitoring, low involvement, and poor communication are associated with higher risk; the participants described both sides of this finding, sometimes within a single case. Uçur and Dönmez (2021) likewise identified low perceived social support as a predictor of problematic gaming. The family is also the factor that clinicians quoted in the national discussion of gaming and violence asked practitioners to weigh, together with conflict at home (Santos, 2026). In bioecological terms, the family is the adolescent’s most immediate microsystem, the setting in which proximal processes are strongest (Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007), so it is consistent that the same family could both push an adolescent toward gaming and hold the support that balances it. The finding also anticipates Theme 3.4, where parents appear again, this time as the people psychologists must work with to change the adolescent’s routine.

Theme 2.3: Online Peers as Belonging and as Risk

Because most adolescent gaming is now online and social, three participants treated the people adolescents meet in games as a factor in themselves. Gaming communities offered friendship and belonging, and for introverted or neurodivergent adolescents they could serve as protection from rejection in person. Interviewee 5, speaking of adolescents on the autism spectrum,

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described the gaming community as a shield, because players are known by how they play rather than by how they appear. Interviewee 2 drew on personal experience of lasting friendships formed through online play (27:18). The same communities, however, could expose adolescents to harmful influence, harassment, exclusion, exploitation, and grooming, and Interviewee 4 cautioned that groups may “gamify” their aims so that young players become confused between the game and reality. The following extracts present both sides.

“Kasi ngayon ’yung online gaming is... is social also diba? Hindi kagaya ng sa console ka lang, nag-ggame ka lang ganon. Pag online you are in a community diba? You play with other people. And so um... kapag ’yung... the people you encounter there are, are parang... are not good influence, so they can influence you, siguro that’s another level of gaming, when we talk online gaming.”

[Because now, online gaming is also social, right? It is not like when you are only on a console, just playing by yourself. When you are online, you are in a community, right? You play with other people. And so, when the people you encounter there are not a good influence, they can influence you. Perhaps that is another level of gaming when we talk about online gaming.] (Interviewee 4, 39:51)

“’yung grooming, ’yung other people uh influence uh young people online diba in certain communities, pag napunta ka sa community na ’yon may grooming, using games, ’yung ganon. So parang... kunyari they’re... they gamify something, but then, if you’re young, you get confused uh between the game and your reality noh.”

[There is grooming: other people influencing young people online, in certain communities. When you end up in that community, there is grooming using games, that kind of thing. So, for example, they gamify something, but if you are young, you get confused between the game and your reality.] (Interviewee 4, 38:11)

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“ang sinasabi nila is more than the game, ’yung trash talk daw. Well because, walang filter do’n, no, uh, tapos importante din sigurong malaman kung sa online gaming na ’yon may nangyayari bang harassment, exclusion, gan’yan, exploitation, gan’yan, no.”

[What they say is that it is more than the game: it is the trash talk, because there is no filter there. And it is also important, perhaps, to know whether harassment, exclusion, or exploitation is happening in that online gaming space.]
(Interviewee 5, 18:11)

“Kasi sa in-person community kasi nahihirapan sila to be accepted. To be acknowledged. Parang ganyan. Pero ’yung sa gaming community na ’yun, hindi mo, minsan hindi mo naman nakikita ’yung kalaro mo, diba. So, hindi mo na kayang ipakita ’yung totoong ikaw. Basta alam mo lang laruin ang game. So, it becomes a shield. A protection.”

[Because in the in-person community, they find it hard to be accepted, to be acknowledged, things like that. But in that gaming community, sometimes you do not even see the person you are playing with, right? So the real you does not have to be shown. You just need to know how to play the game. So it becomes a shield, a protection.] (Interviewee 5, 28:38)

This theme reflects the review’s description of gaming environments as social spaces whose features actively shape experience. Rehbein et al. (2024) found that mandatory social interaction was among the game features most strongly associated with gaming-disorder indicators, and Giardina et al. (2024) describe online games as offering a sense of connection that may compensate for difficulties in offline relationships, the same protective and risky sides the participants described. Encallado et al. (2024) reported social connection through friends as one of the main drivers of gaming among Filipino senior high school students, and Bitto Urbanova et al. (2023) identified vulnerability in virtual spaces as one of the risks adolescents themselves perceive. The concern about groups that use games to reach young people also matches the concern raised in

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the Senate inquiry described in Chapter 1, where lawmakers pointed to organized online groups that exploit a young person's need to belong (Bacelonia, 2026). In bioecological terms, online peers form a microsystem of their own, one that parents and teachers often cannot observe directly (Bronfenbrenner, 1979); its influence therefore reaches the psychologist mainly through what the adolescent is willing to describe.

Theme 2.4: The Game's Content, Cost, and Public Image

Four participants named factors outside the adolescent's immediate circle. Immersive games with storylines and role-playing were said to blur the line between the player and the character. Spending was raised as a concern: Interviewee 2 described students who became addicted to gacha games, which made gaming "an expensive hobby" (17:50), and called loot boxes a form of gambling (50:13), and Interviewee 5 asked adolescents how much they spend, for example on weapons (18:11). Interviewee 5 added that peer influence and social media advertisements can draw people in, citing clients whose gambling addiction began with advertisements that popped up on their phones (32:21). The hope of an e-sports career was also named: Interviewee 2 had a senior high school student who stopped attending classes in order to become a professional player. Finally, the public image of gaming entered the psychologists' judgment. Recent shooting incidents that public discussion associated with gaming made Interviewee 5 "more... cautious of the type of game" (18:11), a caution the participant tied to an already angry, vulnerable adolescent rather than to games in general (22:56). Interviewee 2 and Interviewee 3, on the other hand, warned against blaming games: Interviewee 2 pointed instead to problems at home, and Interviewee 3 cited research showing an association between gaming and aggression but not causation. The following extracts present these wider factors.

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“gaming has, has actually diversified, like the experience of gaming, compared to 20 years ago, is so much different now. Hindi lang ’yung mismong content is very realistic, of course, they’re more interesting now, may storyline pa ’di ba? and then you have, you have an option to anong tawag mo do’n? ’Yung, you are one of the characters. There’s a role playing aspect. So, talagang, mai-immersed ka du’n sa game, it’s like virtual reality. So, it’s not just a game anymore, it’s parang, for a while, it becomes your reality ’no. [...] Minsan nga, I don’t know, it seems that there is a blurring of the distinction between the person and the character.”

[Gaming has actually diversified; the experience of gaming, compared with 20 years ago, is so much different now. It is not only that the content itself is very realistic; of course they are more interesting now, and there is even a storyline, right? And then you have the option, what do you call it, where you are one of the characters. There is a role-playing aspect. So you really become immersed in the game; it is like virtual reality. So it is not just a game anymore; for a while, it becomes your reality. [...] Sometimes, I do not know, it seems that there is a blurring of the distinction between the person and the character.] (Interviewee 4, 42:44)

“the gaming is slowly becoming a professional scene. So, hindi naman siya basketball noh but, as you can see the people are playing online... professional matches. So, because of that, nagkakaroon na ng acceptance, to the point na meron akong estudyante ayaw niya raw pumasok noh. Ano siya umm, senior high. So nagsabi siya, ano sabi niya. Hindi raw siya pumapasok kasi gusto niyang maging professional e-sports player.”

[Gaming is slowly becoming a professional scene. It is not basketball, but as you can see, people are playing professional matches online. Because of that, there is now acceptance, to the point that I had a student, a senior high school student, who did not want to go to school. He told me that he was not attending classes because he wanted to become a professional e-sports player.] (Interviewee 2, 21:25)

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“most of the cases ng school shootings ngayon were adolescents. So usually, pag may ganyang incident, ang sinisisi nila gaming. Common na common ’yan, no. We always look for something to blame, no. Laging ang pinakamadaling sisihin diyan, siyempre, games, cellphone. But culturally, no, people don’t look at the external, other factors, no. Like sa bahay, sa family, baka may problem, ’yun ’yung tipping point.”

[In most of the school shooting cases now, the ones involved were adolescents. So usually, when there is an incident like that, what people blame is gaming. That is very common. We always look for something to blame, and the easiest things to blame are, of course, games and cellphones. But culturally, people do not look at the other, external factors, like the home or the family. Maybe there is a problem there, and that is the tipping point.] (Interviewee 2, 50:13)

“studies suggest na may association between adolescent gaming and aggression, but not causation. Kasi alam naman natin, association doesn’t mean cause and effect. So kung may role man na gusto kong ipabatid is, hindi conclusive na violent games equates to being violent. ’Yun ’yung gusto ko sigurong i-emphasize, na multi-dimensional kasi ’yung gaming and ’yung behavior. [...] So we have to be mindful of that.”

[Studies suggest that there is an association between adolescent gaming and aggression, but not causation, because, as we know, association does not mean cause and effect. So if there is one point I want to make known, it is that it is not conclusive that violent games equate to being violent. That is what I would like to emphasize: gaming and behavior are multidimensional. [...] So we have to be mindful of that.] (Interviewee 3, 38:29)

These factors belong to the gaming environment itself and to the wider systems around it. The concern with immersion and with gacha and loot-box spending reflects the review’s description of gaming environments as designed spaces whose reward structures engage the brain’s reward pathways (Sussman et al., 2018), and Rehbein et al. (2024) found that the number of

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reward categories in a game was among the structural features most strongly associated with gaming-disorder indicators. In PPCT terms, the design decisions of game companies and the advertisements that reach adolescents act through the exosystem, settings in which adolescents do not take part but which shape what they experience (Bronfenbrenner, 1979), while the public discussion of gaming after violent incidents belongs to the macrosystem and to the present historical moment.

The disagreement about violence follows the same line as the national discussion described in Chapter 1. Lawmakers and clinicians had cautioned that the reported links between gaming and the Tacloban shooting were unverified and that no causal link between gaming and aggression has been shown (Bacelonia, 2026; Santos, 2026). Interviewee 3's distinction between association and causation applies the same caution, and Interviewee 2's turn toward the home points back to the family factors in Theme 2.2. Interviewee 5's added caution shows that the public discussion also reaches practitioners who weigh the adolescent's vulnerability rather than the game alone: it changes which games they ask about.

Theme 2.5: Interlocking Factors Whose Weight Differs per Adolescent

All seven participants described the factors as connected, with a weight that differs from one adolescent to another. Interviewee 1 and Interviewee 5 independently described the same cycle: stress leads to gaming, gaming disrupts sleep and school, and the resulting failure brings more stress and more gaming. Interviewee 3 described a related progression, from playing out of boredom to playing out of habit and finally to being hooked, at which point daily functioning is affected, and the participant searched for the "thread" connecting an adolescent's appearance, behavior, sleep, and family relationships in order to find "the weakest link" (18:20). Which factor weighed most was said to differ by personality, family, upbringing, coping skills, age, the company



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the adolescent plays with, how immersed the adolescent is, and socioeconomic status; both Interviewee 3 (20:13) and Interviewee 6 (written response, item 2d) named socioeconomic background. Interviewee 1 drew the practical consequence: because “the same activity can function” differently for different adolescents, “individualized assessment is important” (25:07). Interviewee 5 added that the weight of a factor depends on its effect rather than its amount: a long session may affect nothing, while a short one may include compulsive spending. Motives also differed, from coping with a death in the family to loneliness, belonging, and boredom (Interviewee 5, 28:38). Several participants added that the real reason behind an adolescent’s gaming often surfaced only after several sessions, especially when minors were brought in by their parents. Interviewee 2 was the exception on this last point, having not encountered a case that the usual factors failed to explain (30:54). The following extracts present how the factors interlock.

“an adolescents, who, for example, may be experiencing stress in their academics or their family, can turn to gaming for relief, and gaming can actually provide them support, social support, okay, uh, a way for them to regulate their emotions. However, if it becomes excessive, it can affect other areas of their life also. Babalik ulit ’yon, magiging loop siya. It can affect their academics, it can affect their sleep, their physical health. Which will then create more stress, and lead them to relying on gaming even more. [...] So, uh, I tend to understand it as a cycle, rather than just an isolated behavior.”

[An adolescent who, for example, may be experiencing stress in their academics or their family can turn to gaming for relief, and gaming can actually provide them support, social support, a way for them to regulate their emotions. However, if it becomes excessive, it can affect other areas of their life too. It comes back around and becomes a loop. It can affect their academics, their sleep, their physical health, which then creates more stress and leads them to rely on gaming even more. [...] So I tend to understand it as a cycle rather than just an isolated behavior.] (Interviewee 1, 22:03)

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“It’s more of a cycle. Halimbawa, an adolescent experience academic or family stress, no, nagge-gaming siya, for relief, okay, uh, and then, uh, mags-sleep siya nang late, mags-struggle siya sa school, babagsak siya, then bumagsak siya, magge-gaming na naman siya, kasi tinatry niyang mag-cope sa pain na bumagsak siya. Parang ganyan, no. So, cycle lang siya.”

[It is more of a cycle. For example, an adolescent experiences academic or family stress, so they play games for relief, and then they sleep late, struggle in school, and fail. And after failing, they play games again, because they are trying to cope with the pain of failing. It is like that. So it is just a cycle.]
(Interviewee 5, 24:45)

“So, wala talaga sa number of hours. So, it makes you, siguro it’s the level of dysfunction. Anong level ka na ng dysfunction? [...] ’Yung iba naman, very short lang ’yung period of gaming nila, pero parang, what if short ’yung period, pero may compulsive spending? Gumastos siya nang napakalaki sa isang oras na naglaro. Okay. So, nagva-vary siya. [...] ’Yung isa long, long hours, pero wala naman naapektuhan pa. Pero ’yung isa shorter, pero halimbawa may impulsive buying na nangyari or excessive spending.”

[So it really is not in the number of hours. It is perhaps the level of dysfunction: what level of dysfunction are you at? [...] For others, their gaming period is very short, but what if the period is short and there is compulsive spending? They spent a very large amount in one hour of play. So it varies. [...] One plays long, long hours, but nothing has been affected yet. But another plays for a shorter time, yet, for example, impulsive buying or excessive spending happened.]
(Interviewee 5, 25:40)

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“dahil sila ay minors, dala-dala ng parents nila. So hindi sila masyadong nag-o-open, ’yung ibang clients, about this. [...] So definitely there was an instance na they could have opened more, but they didn’t because of, maybe, ’yun nga, nahihiya, dahil nandoon sila out of obligation, dahil dinala sila ng parents nila doon. It’s not something they did out of initiative.”

[Because they are minors, they are brought in by their parents. So some clients do not open up much about this. [...] So there was definitely an instance where they could have opened up more, but they did not, maybe because they were embarrassed, because they were there out of obligation, because their parents had brought them there. It was not something they did on their own initiative.]
(Interviewee 3, 20:55)

“It depends on how they are immersed with gaming. Some adolescents value it so much that it begins to impair their relationship with their family”
(Interviewee 7, written response, item 2d)

This theme states, in the participants’ own terms, the configurational view at the center of Chapter 1. Dienlin and Johannes (2020) argue that the effects of digital media depend on individual characteristics, patterns of use, and context rather than on the technology itself, and Yang et al. (2024), working from the same bioecological model, found that process, person, and contextual factors together were related to adolescents’ nonacademic digital media use. The stress-gaming-sleep cycle described independently by Interviewee 1 and Interviewee 5 is a concrete example of what Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) call a proximal process: a recurring interaction whose effects build over time and feed back into the person. The insistence on individualized assessment echoes Lo et al. (2021), whose practitioners stressed that cases of adolescent internet addiction are heterogeneous and must be served individually, and it supports the review’s conclusion that gaming outcomes cannot be explained by exposure alone. Interviewee 5’s point about spending

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adds that the dimension that matters may not be time at all, consistent with the attention Rehbein et al. (2024) give to a game's reward structures.

The observation that the real reasons surface only over time has a practical consequence that the reviewed studies did not discuss: an assessment based on the first session, or on the parent's complaint alone, may give weight to the wrong factor. Interviewee 2's contrary account, in which the usual factors had always been sufficient, was kept as reported.

Themes for SOP 3

How do psychologists in Luzon describe their practice in responding to gaming-related concerns among adolescents, in terms of: (a) the benefits and the concerns they identify in adolescents' gaming; (b) the challenges they face as practitioners; and (c) the strategies they employ?

Six themes describe how the psychologists responded to gaming-related concerns. Following the structure of SOP 3, three themes concern the benefits and concerns they identified, one concerns the challenges they faced, and two concern the strategies they used.

(a) Benefits and Concerns***Theme 3.1: Relief, Connection, and Skills***

Six of the seven participants named benefits of gaming; Interviewee 6 was "not sure" of any (written response, item 3a). The benefits most often named were relaxation and stress relief, which Interviewee 7 also described ("They are able to use it to de-stress"; written response, item 3a), enjoyment and recreation, friendship and teamwork, a safe space and a sense of belonging for introverted adolescents, and skills in problem solving, strategy, cooperation, and creativity; Interviewee 5 added that recreation matters in itself because "life is hard" (34:08). Interviewee 2 observed that introverted adolescents can become extroverts online (32:12) and connected the belonging found in gaming communities to *kapwa*, the Filipino sense of shared identity.

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Interviewee 4, who otherwise held the most concerned view in the study, acknowledged that distraction through gaming can be a healthy form of coping in moderation. The following extracts present the benefits the psychologists observed.

“it can be their way of relaxation, for them to enjoy, for them to have social connections, and for some, a sense of achievement, especially for the competitive ones. [...] And sometimes can also be a safe space for them, especially when they have difficulty connecting in person. Yung mga very introverted na individuals, diba, parang for them, yun yung safe space nila.”

[It can be their way of relaxing, of enjoying themselves, of having social connections, and for some, a sense of achievement, especially for the competitive ones. [...] And sometimes it can also be a safe space for them, especially when they have difficulty connecting in person. For very introverted individuals, it is like their safe space.] (Interviewee 1, question 3a)

“there’s a stigma, di ba, pag gamer ka, ganito ka. So hindi siya nare-reinforce, but you get to find your own people. Then you get to meet a lot of friends. [...] So alam mo ’yun, mas comfortable kasi that they speak the same language. ’Yun ’yung kapwa, that sense of community, your sense of kapwa.”

[There is a stigma, right? If you are a gamer, you are like this. So that stigma is not reinforced; instead, you get to find your own people. Then you get to meet a lot of friends. [...] So, you know, they are more comfortable because they speak the same language. That is kapwa, that sense of community, your sense of kapwa.] (Interviewee 2, 41:36)

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“critical thinking din, problem solving. Kasi marami yung problems ngayon, yung mga arcade, yung mga RPG. 'Di ba may mga ganong mga scenarios na you have to think outside the box para ma-solve mo yung situation. You need to gather these materials para ma-open mo yung certain areas. You need to do teamwork para ma-defeat niyo yung boss.”

[Also critical thinking and problem solving. There are many problems now in arcade games and RPGs, right? There are scenarios where you have to think outside the box to solve the situation. You need to gather materials to open certain areas. You need teamwork to defeat the boss.] (Interviewee 3, 22:06)

“To some degree, distraction is really a form of coping. And it can even be healthy. Like 'yung kapag mayroon kang intrusive thoughts, you can distract yourself, okay naman 'yun.”

[To some degree, distraction is really a form of coping, and it can even be healthy. For example, when you have intrusive thoughts, you can distract yourself, and that is fine.] (Interviewee 4, 13:36)

These benefits match those reported in the reviewed literature. Nagata et al. (2026) describe genuine developmental and health benefits of video games, particularly when play is driven by interest and paired with self-regulation, and Encallado et al. (2024) found that Filipino senior high school students described enjoyment, social connection, and stress relief through gaming. The safe space described for introverted adolescents corresponds to the compensatory function of gaming environments described by Giardina et al. (2024). Interviewee 2's reference to *kapwa* is the clearest point at which the Filipino cultural material reviewed in Chapter 1 appeared in the data: the participant described gaming communities as places where players “speak the same language,” which is the shared identity that Enriquez placed at the center of *Sikolohiyang Pilipino* (Enriquez, 1978, as cited in Maninang, 2025).

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Interviewee 6's uncertainty is a reminder that benefits were not visible to every practitioner. This participant's written answers described adolescents who came to the clinic already showing negative effects (written response, item 3b), so the cases seen in that practice may lean toward harm; with no follow-up possible, the answer was reported as it was given.

Theme 3.2: Gaming That Disrupts Daily Functioning

The concerns centered on gaming that displaces ordinary life: lost sleep, skipped meals and hygiene, falling grades or leaving school, physical inactivity, and withdrawal from the family (Interviewee 1, question 3b). Interviewee 3 described adolescents who stopped bathing, eating, and sleeping enough and who isolated themselves from their significant others (23:20), and Interviewee 5 added the physical effects of long hours of sitting (35:51). Participants also described irritability, outbursts, or aggression when gaming is stopped or interrupted, withdrawal symptoms like those of other addictions (Interviewee 5, 08:38), loss of control, excessive spending, and exposure to harmful content, cyberbullying, and online predators. Interviewee 6 wrote that adolescents who visited clinics for gaming issues "usually presented with negative effects" and that gaming had, in some cases, become "uncontrollable" (written response, item 3b). Interviewee 1 set the threshold in the same terms as Theme 1.3: concern begins "when the gaming begins interfering with their everyday function" (question 3b). Not all accounts agreed. Interviewee 2 named sleep loss and spending but saw no psychological concern among the students that participant knew, whose coping was described as good, and Interviewee 5 described students who played for hours and still kept high grades, although the participant still called gaming in class inappropriate (34:08). Interviewee 4 went further than the other participants and described a pattern the participant called screen-mediated neurodivergence, presented as a tentative clinical term. The following extracts present the concerns and the accounts that qualified them.

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“Some, dahil lagi sila naglalaro, they become too competitive, posibleng nagiging irritable sila. Yung iba naman, kapag nai-interrupt yung gaming nila, talagang nagwawala sila. They find it difficult to regulate their emotions. Tapos, nawawalan na rin sila ng sense of control with the amount of time that they’re playing.”

[Some, because they are always playing, become too competitive and may become irritable. Others, when their gaming is interrupted, really lash out. They find it difficult to regulate their emotions. And they also lose their sense of control over the amount of time they spend playing.] (Interviewee 1, question 3b)

“Impaired relationships with family members - the manner of how they comply with instructions, emotion regulation/outbursts when interrupted or delayed” (Interviewee 7, written response, item 3b)

“’yung exposure sa harmful content, lalo na kung nasa dark web ’yung game. Cyberbullying, inappropriate contact, because, ’yung online predators could be present in gaming communities, na, kunwari nagga-game din sila, pero pwede sila, sex predators.”

[Exposure to harmful content, especially if the game is on the dark web. Cyberbullying and inappropriate contact, because online predators could be present in gaming communities, pretending to be gamers too, but they could be sex predators.] (Interviewee 5, 35:51)

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“Isa sa mga concern na na-observe ko, finances. Then, other than that, parang wala na naman na. Usually, yung ano lang talaga, possible banning and finances, after that kasi nahihirapan din sila kapag they’re very well immersed. Lagi silang puyat, usually during my class, puyat na puyat sila. Pero psychologically, parang wala naman akong nakikitang concern so far. Kasi nga maganda yung coping nila. They can cope properly.”

[One of the concerns I have observed is finances. Other than that, there is nothing much. Usually it is really just the possibility of being banned, and finances. After that, they also have difficulty when they are very immersed. They always lack sleep; usually during my class, they are very sleepy. But psychologically, I do not see any concern so far, because their coping is good. They can cope properly.] (Interviewee 2, 33:22)

“Ang tawag namin screen-mediated neurodivergent disorder. So hindi siya autism spectrum disorder. Screen-mediated neurodivergence. [...] Pero napapansin namin dumadami ’yung mga meron ASD saka ADHD symptoms niya. And our theory is that they’re not really born with ADHD or ASD. ’Yun kaya lang, they’ve been exposed to screens since maybe toddlerhood or early childhood. That’s why they developed these symptoms. [...] Pag inalis mo ’yung screen use, nawawala, nagre-remit, nawawala ’yung symptoms nila.”

[What we call it is screen-mediated neurodivergent disorder. So it is not autism spectrum disorder; it is screen-mediated neurodivergence. [...] But we notice that more and more have ASD and ADHD symptoms. And our theory is that they are not really born with ADHD or ASD; it is just that they have been exposed to screens since maybe toddlerhood or early childhood. That is why they developed these symptoms. [...] When you remove the screen use, their symptoms go away; they remit.] (Interviewee 4, 18:24)

The concerns follow the line that the reviewed literature draws between problematic gaming and ordinary play. King and Delfabbro (2019) define problematic gaming by its adverse effects on personal life and on academic or occupational responsibilities, and the ICD-11

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description of gaming disorder centers on impaired control and continuation despite negative consequences (WHO, 2020); the participants' concerns, displaced sleep and self-care, loss of control, and outbursts when play is interrupted, are the everyday signs of the same criteria. Encallado et al. (2024) reported the same costs of disrupted sleep and missed meals among Filipino senior high school gamers, and Bitto Urbanova et al. (2023) found that adolescents themselves perceive problematic control and health risks in their use of digital technology. The concern about predators parallels the vulnerability in virtual spaces described by the adolescents in that study and the online groups discussed in the Senate inquiry (Bacelonia, 2026).

The qualifying accounts are as informative as the concerns. Interviewee 5's high-achieving students who game for hours show that time spent is not the deciding factor, consistent with Theme 1.3, and Interviewee 2's view that students in that practice cope well is consistent with the estimate of the WHO Regional Office for Europe (2024) that only a minority of adolescents (12%) were at risk of problematic gaming. Interviewee 4's screen-mediated neurodivergence is reported as the participant's own tentative term. The study the participant referred to was not named, and the reviewed literature describes associations between screen use and outcomes rather than the causal effect the term implies, so it is not presented here as an established finding.

Theme 3.3: Benefits and Concerns in the Same Adolescent

Five of the seven psychologists had seen benefits and concerns in the same adolescent. Interviewee 1 described this as "quite common": gaming could help an adolescent cope with stress while also contributing to poor sleep, procrastination, and self-neglect. Gaming could give an adolescent the friendship and sense of accomplishment they needed while also causing late nights and conflict at home, often because parents did not understand the benefits the adolescent was getting. For this reason, the psychologists avoided labeling gaming as simply good or bad.



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Interviewee 5 called gaming a double-edged sword whose value depends on “how the person who uses the game regulate[s] his or her behavior” (38:32), and Interviewee 4 placed it “in the middle” (26:13): it cannot be eliminated and has real benefits, but beyond a limit it becomes addiction. Interviewee 3 drew a further distinction between what is beneficial to the adolescent personally and what is healthy, treating distress in the family and disrupted daily activities as the red flag (26:50). Interviewee 6 wrote that gaming “can serve as a stress reliever, but it should be within a controlled limit” (written response, item 2c), and Interviewee 7 confirmed such a case by referring back to earlier answers, in which de-stressing and impaired family relationships appeared together (written response, item 3c). Interviewee 2 and Interviewee 6 had not encountered such a case (Interviewee 2, 35:44; Interviewee 6, written response, item 3c). The following extracts present how benefits and concerns met in the same adolescent.

“it’s actually quite common. The good and the bad, right? Uhm-gaming, ’been actually ’no, in some cases, I do have clients wherein in gaming it helps them cope with their stress, but at the same time. It also contributes to the poor sleep quality, to procrastination, to forgetting about taking care of themselves ’no? That’s why I avoid labeling gaming as simply good or bad kase it can be both. The-th-the habit or gaming, can have both protective factors for the individuals, but it can also have problematic functions occurring at the same time.”

[It is actually quite common, the good and the bad, right? In some cases, I do have clients for whom gaming helps them cope with their stress, but at the same time, it also contributes to poor sleep quality, to procrastination, to forgetting to take care of themselves. That is why I avoid labeling gaming as simply good or bad, because it can be both. The habit of gaming can have protective factors for the individual, but it can also have problematic functions occurring at the same time.] (Interviewee 1, 34:38)

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“gaming may give an adolescent, uhm, the friendship that he or she probably needs. Nakaka-enjoy, may sense of accomplishment kapag nananalo ka, okay, pero ano ba ’yung at the same time, ’yung concern do’n? ’Yung late night use siyempre. Pinaka-importante ’yung sleep kasi, no, uh, neglected responsibilities. Conflict at home. Kasi ’yung mga parents, hindi naman lahat naiintindihan nila ’yung dynamics ng gaming. ’Di naman nila naiintindihan na may benefits din ang gaming. Basta alam nila ’pag nagge-game ka, you’re not using your time well. Correct? So it’s leading to a lot of family conflict, okay. So nage-enjoy ka but at the same time, nagkakaroon ka ng conflict din sa ibang tao so ’yon, no. So, the coexistence of the benefit and the concern.”

[Gaming may give an adolescent the friendship that they probably need. It is enjoyable, and there is a sense of accomplishment when you win. But at the same time, what is the concern there? Late-night use, of course; sleep is the most important. Neglected responsibilities. Conflict at home, because not all parents understand the dynamics of gaming. They do not understand that gaming also has benefits. All they know is that when you play games, you are not using your time well. Correct? So it leads to a lot of family conflict. So you are enjoying, but at the same time, you are also having conflict with other people. So, the coexistence of the benefit and the concern.] (Interviewee 5, 38:32)

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“they claim na through gaming, sumasaya sila. May happiness involved, and ’yun na lang ’yung escape nila sa reality. And ’yung nagiging concerning doon is, ’yun nga, wala nang boundaries, nagiging sobra. Wala na siyang time lumabas ng bahay. Wala na silang time maki-deal sa mga family members nila. So ’yun siguro ’yung scenario na I could cite, na it’s both beneficial personally for the client and concerning in general.”

[They say that gaming makes them happy. There is happiness involved, and it has become their only escape from reality. What becomes concerning is that there are no more boundaries; it becomes too much. They no longer have time to go out of the house. They no longer have time to deal with their family members. So perhaps that is the scenario I could cite, where it is both personally beneficial for the client and concerning in general.] (Interviewee 3, 25:01)

“gaming cannot be eliminated completely. Mayroon din naman siyang benefits like for leisure, for minsan ’yung mga strategies you learn, it helps a person develop cognitive strategies. But then there’s a limit to that. [...] So kapag sumosobra na, nagkakaroon ng gaming addiction. And nawawalan na ng control pag ganun, hindi na nareregulate ’yung sarili, hindi na kayang pigilan ’yung urge to play the game and to stop.”

[Gaming cannot be eliminated completely. It also has benefits, such as for leisure, and sometimes the strategies you learn help a person develop cognitive strategies. But then there is a limit to that. [...] So when it becomes too much, gaming addiction develops. And when that happens, the person loses control, can no longer regulate themselves, and can no longer resist the urge to play or bring themselves to stop.] (Interviewee 4, 27:39)

This theme is the clearest expression in the data of the position the study adopted in Chapter 1: that gaming is neither a uniform threat nor a uniform benefit. The same coexistence appears in the reviewed studies. Encallado et al. (2024) found that the gaming of Filipino senior high school students was rarely wholly good or wholly bad, with enjoyment, connection, and stress relief

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described alongside disrupted sleep and missed meals, and Bitto Urbanova et al. (2023) found that adolescents who depended on digital technology also recognized its risks. Vanden Abeele (2021) explains why this is expected: if digital well-being is a balance, the same activity can add to one side of it and take from the other. The psychologists' refusal to label gaming as good or bad is the practical form of this balance, and Interviewee 3's distinction between what is beneficial to the adolescent and what is healthy gives the practitioner a way to keep both sides in view.

In bioecological terms, the same proximal process can produce both competence and dysfunction depending on the person and the context (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007), which is why the benefits and concerns in this theme were seldom separable. The two participants who had not encountered such a case, one of whom answered in writing without follow-up, were reported as negative cases.

(b) Challenges***Theme 3.4: Resistant Parents and the Adolescent's Own Commitment***

All seven participants named challenges in responding to gaming-related concerns, and parents were mentioned most often. Some parents saw gaming as the whole problem while the adolescent saw it as enjoyment or connection; others excused the gaming as normal for a child, did not agree with the psychologist's intervention, were not at home to enforce limits, or gave the gadget back when the adolescent threw a tantrum. Interviewee 6 described an adolescent so detached from the family that the issues the family raised no longer registered (written response, item 3d). Once gaming had become a habit or the adolescent's main way of coping, the challenge shifted to securing the adolescent's own commitment to change, which Interviewee 7 described as helping adolescents regulate their use "in a healthier manner" (written response, item 3d). Interviewee 5 described the particular difficulty of an adolescent with depression or anxiety who



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insists on gaming as the only way of coping and so no longer moves or goes out (39:48), and Interviewee 4 noted that a case may reach the level of addiction, which lies outside that participant's specialization. The psychologists also found it difficult to tell whether gaming was the main problem or a response to something else (Interviewee 1, question 3d), and Interviewee 2 described the more ordinary challenge of students arriving in class sleepless after long gaming sessions (36:49). The following extracts present these challenges.

“one of the challenges for me is the difference between how adolescents perceive gaming, and how older people, the adults, see gaming. For example, most cases kase, kapag gaming ’yung nilalapit na concern, these are the parents... and parents would immediately view gaming as the main problem. While for the-the adolescent, they see it as their main source of enjoyment or s-for social connection”

[One of the challenges for me is the difference between how adolescents perceive gaming and how older people, the adults, see gaming. For example, in most cases, when gaming is the concern being brought to me, it is the parents who bring it, and parents immediately view gaming as the main problem. While the adolescent sees it as their main source of enjoyment or of social connection.]
(Interviewee 1, question 3d)

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“Siguro ’yung main challenge, eh, minsan ’yung parents. Kasi may mga parents na hinahayaan ’yung mga anak nila. And minsan jina-justify ng parent ’yung actions ng anak, na kesyo dahil siguro bata kaya ganyan. [...] So ’yun ’yung most challenging, kapag hindi mo kasama, or hindi mo na-meet ’yung expectations ng parents niya, and hindi sila nag-a-agree sa intervention mo.”

[Perhaps the main challenge, sometimes, is the parents. Because there are parents who just let their children be. And sometimes the parent justifies the child’s actions, saying that the child is like that just because they are young. [...] So that is the most challenging: when the parents are not with you, or you have not met the parents’ expectations, and they do not agree with your intervention.]
(Interviewee 3, 28:10)

“hindi ako nahihirapan dun sa adolescent, nahihirapan ako dun sa parents. Una, because this is not solely the concern of the therapist, or the psychologist, or the counselor, kasi kapag dinala ’yun sa clinic, ang una naming sasabihin sa parent is kailangan maregulate ’yung gadget use sa bahay. Pero, halimbawa, ang problema, the whole day wala ’yung parents, nagtatrabaho sila. Wala naman mag-regulate dun sa gadget use. Kumbaga, free ’yung bata to use ’yung gadget anytime”

[I do not struggle with the adolescent; I struggle with the parents. First, because this is not solely the concern of the therapist, the psychologist, or the counselor. When a case is brought to the clinic, the first thing we tell the parent is that gadget use at home needs to be regulated. But, for example, the problem is that the parents are away the whole day because they are working. There is no one to regulate the gadget use. In a way, the child is free to use the gadget anytime.]
(Interviewee 5, 39:48)

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“Pero sino ba ang mag-i-implement ng schedule? Hindi naman ang therapist ’yon. Kung sino ’yung kasama niya sa bahay. Ang problema nila hindi nai-implement ng mga kasama niya sa bahay. It’s either wala sila or na-psychologically manipulated na sila ng bata. Na [kapag] kinuha or binawasan ’yung oras, nagwawala. And therefore, wala choice ’yung parent or any caregiver, kundi ibalik.”

[But who will implement the schedule? It is not the therapist; it is whoever lives with the adolescent at home. Their problem is that the schedule is not implemented by the people at home. Either they are not there, or they have already been psychologically manipulated by the child: when the gadget is taken away or the time is reduced, the child throws a tantrum. And therefore, the parent or any caregiver has no choice but to give it back.] (Interviewee 5, 39:48)

“the challenging part is when you realize that it has solidified so much, it has become habitual to the point of addiction na. The question is, so how do you treat it as an addiction? And I’m not an addiction professional. [...] So you really need to engage the person’s commitment, educate them that why this is not good for them. So you can get their commitment to change. You need to motivate them, motivational interviewing.”

[The challenging part is when you realize that it has solidified so much; it has become habitual to the point of addiction. The question then is how you treat it as an addiction, and I am not an addiction professional. [...] So you really need to engage the person’s commitment and educate them on why this is not good for them, so that you can get their commitment to change. You need to motivate them: motivational interviewing.] (Interviewee 4, 45:32)

The central role of parents in this theme echoes Lo et al. (2021), whose practitioners described family involvement in adolescent internet-addiction treatment as both essential and challenging. The specific difficulties the participants named, parents who see gaming as the whole problem, parents who excuse it, parents who are absent, and caregivers who give in to tantrums,

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correspond to the parental mediation patterns reviewed by Nielsen et al. (2019), who found that no single approach works for every family and that withdrawing from mediation tends to worsen problems, and to the family factors identified by Schneider et al. (2017), in which low involvement and weak monitoring were associated with higher risk. The gap between how adolescents and adults see gaming, named by Interviewee 1, also reflects the generational change described in Theme 1.4.

The second challenge, the adolescent's own commitment, follows from the nature of problematic gaming described in Chapter 1. When gaming has become habitual, the impaired control that defines gaming disorder (WHO, 2020) makes change depend on the adolescent's motivation, which is why Interviewee 4 turned to motivational interviewing. In bioecological terms, these challenges sit where the Person meets the microsystem: the psychologist can recommend a schedule, but whether it is carried out depends on the adolescent's commitment and on the people at home (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007).

(c) Strategies***Theme 3.5: Understanding the Adolescent Before Acting on the Gaming***

Before acting on the gaming itself, the psychologists worked to understand the adolescent. They avoided judging gaming and treated it as having real value for the adolescent; they showed genuine interest and let the adolescent explain why they play (Interviewee 5, 44:57); they assessed every area of the adolescent's life, leaving "no stone... unturned," since gaming might be only one factor (Interviewee 3, 32:02); and they used shared experience with games, or the adolescent's own interest in them, to build rapport. Interviewee 2 described gaming as common ground that removes the adolescent's *ilang*, or awkwardness, and linked it to *pakikipagpalagayang-loob*, the rapport and mutual trust described in *Sikolohiyang Pilipino*. When the client is a gamer, Interviewee 2 used

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this common ground so that the client would see the psychologist as one of “my people” who “speak the same language” (47:50). Interviewee 3 mentioned having gamed at the adolescents’ age as a form of empathy (36:21), and Interviewee 7 wrote that “gaming is central to the lives of some adolescents” and serves as a way “to build rapport and get to know them better” (written response, item 1b). The psychologists also gave adolescents a voice in the intervention plan rather than dictating limits, and they helped parents and adolescents understand each other’s side; Interviewee 6 described looking at “how parents and children can agree on a resolution on how to achieve control” (written response, item 3e). The following extracts present these relational strategies.

“non-judgmental attitude or non-judgmental conversation. You don’t make them feel that gaming is inherently bad because it’s not. In the same way that social media platforms are not inherently bad, it depends on who uses them. So hindi nila dapat agad-agad maramdaman nahuhusgahan sila o masamang tao sila kasi nagga-game sila. Kailangan i-recognize mo na ‘yung gaming, may benefit sa gamer. You have to respect that. Pag ganun kasi, willing siyang sumunod dun sa sasabihin mo na ‘ok lang, basta regulated.’ You’re not supposed to say stop.”

[A non-judgmental attitude, or a non-judgmental conversation. You do not make them feel that gaming is inherently bad, because it is not. In the same way that social media platforms are not inherently bad, it depends on who uses them. So they should not immediately feel that they are being judged, or that they are bad people because they play games. You need to recognize that gaming has benefits for the gamer. You have to respect that. Because when it is like that, they are willing to follow what you tell them, that ‘it is okay, as long as it is regulated.’ You are not supposed to say stop.] (Interviewee 5, 42:46)

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“one of the students, para maging close kami, is that ’yun ’yung ginagamit nilang common ground, no. We have something in common. Tapos because of that, no, nawawala ’yung ilang nila. So nagiging comfortable sila. [...] we have something in common, or we have a common ground, so that, alam mo ’yun, sa Sikolohiyang Pilipino, merong pakikipagpalagayang-loob”

[With one of the students, for us to become close, gaming is what they use as common ground. We have something in common, and because of that, their awkwardness disappears, so they become comfortable. [...] We have something in common, a common ground, so that, you know, in Sikolohiyang Pilipino, there is pakikipagpalagayang-loob.] (Interviewee 2, 10:27)

“effective strategy parati if you are trying to regulate is to involve them in the intervention. Kumbaga, hindi kita didiktahan na o, once a week ka nalang mag-gagame ah, hindi gano’n. Pag ginawa ’yung intervention plan, dapat involved siya. Okay sa tingin mo, anong kaya mo? You have to give the client or the adolescent a voice in the intervention plan. Kasi kapag diniktahan mo lang siya, magre-rebelde lang ’yun”

[An effective strategy, always, if you are trying to regulate, is to involve them in the intervention. In other words, I will not dictate, ‘Okay, you can only play games once a week,’ not like that. When the intervention plan is made, they should be involved: ‘Okay, what do you think you can do?’ You have to give the client or the adolescent a voice in the intervention plan, because if you just dictate to them, they will only rebel.] (Interviewee 5, 44:57)

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“one way to handle it or to deal with it is to make each uh person understand the other side. So in my case, ang gagawin ko non, for the adolescent, I would explain the side of the parent. And also try to... you know parang... uh find ways on how they can- uh, meet- half-way, ganoon din doon sa parent. Kase uh kailangan mong ipa-realize on both sides that there is a gap that exists between them, and if that gap continues to exist, hindi talaga mareresolve yung problema. So, they really have to make adjustments, both of them”

[One way to handle it or deal with it is to make each person understand the other side. So in my case, what I would do is, for the adolescent, I would explain the side of the parent, and also try to find ways for them to meet halfway, and the same with the parent. Because you need to make both sides realize that there is a gap between them, and if that gap continues to exist, the problem will really not be resolved. So they really have to make adjustments, both of them.]
(Interviewee 1, 44:30)

This theme corresponds to the relational strategies described in the reviewed literature. Lo et al. (2021) found that practitioners shifted their focus from the adolescent alone to the relationships around the adolescent and tailored their work to each case, and the participants’ holistic assessment and their work to bridge parents and adolescents follow the same logic. Nielsen et al. (2019) found active, communicative parental mediation more promising than restriction alone, which matches the participants’ preference for conversation and shared limits over dictated rules. The non-judgmental stance also answers the concern-centric tendency noted by Meriläinen et al. (2023): by recognizing gaming’s value before addressing its costs, the psychologists made regulation acceptable to the adolescent.

The use of gaming as common ground connects the findings most directly to the Filipino cultural psychology reviewed in Chapter 1. Maninang (2025) describes how *kapwa* is enacted through *pakikipagkapwa*, moving from the guarded civility of *pakikitungo* toward the rapport and

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ease of *pakikipagpalagayang-loob*, and Interviewee 2 described exactly this movement: shared gaming experience dissolved the adolescent's *ilang* and allowed the psychologist to be seen as "my people" (Interviewee 2, 47:50). This is the clearest evidence in the data for the relevance of Filipino relational concepts to practice. No participant, however, named the Kapampangan value cluster of *pamagmasabal* (Antonio, 2023), even though five of the seven practice in Pampanga; the local cultural meaning anticipated in the framework did not appear explicitly in these accounts.

Theme 3.6: Gradual Regulation, Offline Alternatives, and Psychoeducation

The concrete strategies aimed at regulation rather than prohibition. Interviewee 5 reduced play in small steps and set daily schedules, for example "one hour lang in the morning, one hour lang in the afternoon" [only one hour in the morning, only one hour in the afternoon] (42:46). Interviewee 4 advised balancing screen use with offline and physical activities and recommended the well-being settings on phones, while noting uncertainty about how those settings apply to gaming rather than to scrolling (14:08). Interviewee 6 wrote that school should be prioritized and screen time limited (written response, item 3f), and Interviewee 7 named "family involvement" and alternatives that stimulate the adolescent as much as gaming does, "e.g., sports, other hobbies" (written response, item 3e). Interviewee 2 used games themselves: recommending story-driven, offline games for their relaxing and therapeutic quality (38:20), and suggesting a wish-simulator app to a student drawn to spending on gacha pulls (17:50). The psychologists also used psychoeducation, explaining what sleep loss does to the brain and to mood instead of moralizing, so that adolescents understood why limits mattered. Interviewee 1 explained why prohibition backfires: removing gaming without understanding its function can create resistance or take away the adolescent's outlet without replacing it with something healthier. The following extracts present these strategies.

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“small steps. Small steps. Small steps. Halimbawa, hindi mo sasabihin, kung halimbawa, 2 hours siyang naglalaro, hindi mo sasabihin, 15 minutes na lang. Masyadong malaki ’yon. So instead magbabawas ka, ok, kung dati 2 hours, ngayon 1 hour and a half, kaya niya. The following week, 1 hour 15 minutes, the following weeks, one hour gradual”

[Small steps. Small steps. Small steps. For example, if they play for 2 hours, you will not say, ‘Only 15 minutes from now on.’ That is too big a cut. So instead you reduce it: okay, if it was 2 hours before, now it is 1 hour and a half, which they can manage. The following week, 1 hour and 15 minutes; the following weeks, one hour. Gradually.] (Interviewee 5, 42:46)

“So one intervention is to balance their use. Na ’yung... Halimbawa, ’yung when you use it for work, you cannot really remove it. But when using it for leisure, you need to find other ways of using leisure time that does not involve screens. So kailangan, there’s a variety of activities that you’re doing. And one of the most important things is to make sure meron kang physical activity. [...] In fact, one of the most basic recommendations for depression is to activate your body. To do exercise.”

[So one intervention is to balance their use. For example, when you use it for work, you cannot really remove it. But when using it for leisure, you need to find other ways of spending leisure time that do not involve screens. So there needs to be a variety of activities that you are doing. And one of the most important things is to make sure you have physical activity. [...] In fact, one of the most basic recommendations for depression is to activate your body, to exercise.] (Interviewee 4, 24:15)

“Ang tawag namin dito ’yung psychoeducation. For example, kailangan ’yung i-explain, what happens to the brain when you are deprived of sleep?”

[What we call this is psychoeducation. For example, you need to explain what happens to the brain when you are deprived of sleep.] (Interviewee 5, 44:57)

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“if you completely remove gaming without trying to understand its function, it may create more resistance towards the adolescent, or it may remove, you know, ah an important coping for them or an outlet for them kung hindi mo siya ire-replace into something healthier.”

[If you completely remove gaming without trying to understand its function, it may create more resistance in the adolescent, or it may remove an important way of coping or an outlet for them, if you do not replace it with something healthier.] (Interviewee 1, question 3e)

These strategies follow from the earlier themes and from the literature. Because the psychologists located the problem in function and in disrupted functioning rather than in gaming itself (Themes 1.2 and 1.3), their strategies regulated and replaced rather than prohibited, which is consistent with the review’s evidence that relying on restriction alone, or withdrawing from mediation, tends to be less effective than active, communicative involvement (Nielsen et al., 2019). Lo et al. (2021) similarly describe practitioners who combine individual work with family sessions, as Interviewee 7’s emphasis on family involvement does. The use of offline and physical activities corresponds to the findings of Yang et al. (2024), in which physical activity, adequate sleep, and participation in school and community activities were associated with lower nonacademic digital media use, and psychoeducation about sleep addresses the most basic need named in Theme 2.1. Laffier et al. (2025) describe digital wellness as built through self-awareness and intentional use, which is what psychoeducation and collaborative limits aim to develop.

In bioecological terms, these strategies work on the Process and the Context together: they change the recurring interaction with the game gradually while adding new interactions, such as sports, walks, and time with friends, and they enlist the family as the setting where the plan is carried out (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2007). The strategies are presented as the participants’ professional accounts; the study did not evaluate whether they work.



HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Chapter 4****Discussion**

This chapter discusses the findings in light of the purpose of the study, which was to describe the lived professional experiences of licensed psychologists in Luzon regarding adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments. It begins with the researchers' reflexivity, then summarizes the findings for each statement of the problem, states the conclusions drawn from them, and closes with recommendations.

Reflexivity

The researchers are senior high school students at Holy Angel University in Angeles City, Pampanga, close in age to the adolescents this study is about, and several of them play games themselves. They entered the study holding two opposite assumptions common among their peers and families: that gaming is mostly harmful, which is how many parents see it, and that gaming is mostly harmless, which is how many players see it. These assumptions first led the researchers to frame the problem as a question of risk. Reading the literature, especially the bioecological model of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007), led them to reframe it around the conditions that surround gaming, which is reflected in the study's position that gaming is neither a uniform threat nor a uniform benefit but a complex and individualized experience.

These positions could have affected the study at several points. As gamers, the researchers could have phrased questions in ways that invited participants to defend gaming, and during analysis they could have given more weight to accounts that did. As students in Pampanga, they could have expected Kapampangan cultural values to appear in the data and read them into accounts that did not name them. Before the interviews, the researchers also expected participants to name benefits such as relief, connection, and achievement and concerns involving sleep, self-

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care, school, and loss of control. Several of these expectations appeared in the themes, so the risk of finding only what they expected was real.

The influence mattered most at three points: in writing the interview guide, in choosing which passages to code and quote, and in deciding how to treat accounts that did not fit the emerging pattern. It mattered most of all in the case of Interviewee 4, whose view that screen exposure itself harms the developing brain did not fit the pattern described by most participants, and in the case of the Filipino and Kapampangan cultural concepts anticipated in the framework.

The researchers managed this influence through the design and the analysis. Eligibility was based on a license, professional experience with adolescents, and practice in Luzon, not on a favorable or unfavorable view of gaming. The interview guide left digital well-being undefined for participants to explain, did not prescribe categories under SOP 2, and explicitly asked for cases that the participants' usual explanations did not fit. Initial codes were generated from the participants' own words before the accounts were related to the PPCT model. Accounts that contradicted the themes, such as the participant who saw little psychological concern in gaming and the participants who could not name a benefit or a mixed case, were logged as negative cases and reported within the themes, and Interviewee 4's position was presented as a distinct clinical view rather than set aside. Statements in Filipino were presented as spoken, with translations, so that readers can compare the researchers' interpretation with the participants' own words, and major decisions were recorded in an audit trail.

The researchers acknowledge the limits of what this reflexivity achieved. The sample is small and concentrated in Pampanga, where the researchers themselves study, and two of the seven participants answered in writing with no chance for follow-up questions, so their accounts were used mainly to support themes rather than to build them. Parts of the transcripts were completed

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with automatic transcription and checked against the recordings, and AI assistance was used to draft codes that the researchers then reviewed (see Chapter 2). The cultural material the researchers expected appeared only in one participant's use of *kapwa* and *pakikipagpalagayang-loob*, and the researchers report that absence rather than supply what the participants did not say. The conclusions that follow rest on the recurring themes while keeping the divergent accounts in view.

Summary of Findings

The following summarizes the findings for each statement of the problem.

Psychologists' Lived Professional Experiences of Encountering and Interpreting Adolescent Gaming (SOP 1)

The psychologists seldom received gaming as the reason for a referral; it surfaced behind other concerns such as sleep problems, school refusal, mood, aggression at home, or a parent's complaint (Theme 1.1). They interpreted it by the function it served for the adolescent, whether escape, coping, release, connection, or memory, rather than by its frequency (Theme 1.2), and they defined adolescent digital well-being as the ability to game with balance and control while sleep, school, relationships, and self-care remain intact, not as the absence of gaming (Theme 1.3). Of the five participants who described how their understanding had changed over their careers, four moved from judging the game to understanding the gamer (Theme 1.4). The fifth held a divergent view throughout, locating the harm in screen exposure itself and moving toward greater concern after the pandemic.

Factors That Shape Adolescent Digital Well-Being in Gaming Environments (SOP 2)

The psychologists weighed the adolescent's emotional state, motives, and basic needs, giving sleep, food, and self-care first priority (Theme 2.1); the family, as both the source of the stress that adolescents escape and the support that protects them (Theme 2.2); online peers, as a



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source of belonging and of risk (Theme 2.3); and the game's content, cost, and public image, including immersion, gacha and loot-box spending, hopes of an e-sports career, and public debate about violence (Theme 2.4). All seven described these factors as interlocking: stress, gaming, and lost sleep can feed one another in a cycle, and the weight of each factor differs from one adolescent to another and often becomes clear only over several sessions (Theme 2.5).

Benefits and Concerns, Challenges, and Strategies in Practice (SOP 3)

In terms of benefits and concerns, the psychologists observed relief, connection, belonging, and skills (Theme 3.1) alongside gaming that disrupts sleep, self-care, school, physical health, and family life, with outbursts when play is interrupted, loss of control, spending, and online risks (Theme 3.2), and five of the seven had seen both in the same adolescent (Theme 3.3). In terms of challenges, they named parents, who may see gaming as the whole problem, excuse it, or be unable to enforce limits, and the adolescent's own commitment to change once gaming has become a habit or the main way of coping (Theme 3.4). In terms of strategies, they began by understanding the adolescent through non-judgmental curiosity, holistic assessment, common ground, and shared decisions (Theme 3.5), and then regulated play gradually, offered offline and physical alternatives, involved the family, and used psychoeducation (Theme 3.6).

These findings rest on 203 coded extracts from seven psychologists, five interviewed and two who answered in writing. Eleven of the fifteen themes contain material from at least five participants, and the counts include divergent accounts, so they show how widely a theme was discussed rather than how many participants agreed with it.

Conclusions

Based on the findings, the researchers drew the following conclusions.



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Regarding SOP 1, the researchers conclude that, for these psychologists, adolescent gaming is a matter of function and functioning rather than of hours. Gaming reaches them indirectly, through its effects on sleep, school, mood, and family life, and they judge it by what it does for the adolescent and whether the adolescent keeps balance and control. Digital well-being, in their view, is not the absence of gaming. This agrees with Vanden Abeele (2021) and Feerrar (2022), who describe digital well-being as a dynamic balance and as the capacity to stay healthy while using technology, and with the distinction Columb et al. (2022) draw between enthusiastic and disordered gaming. The one participant who located the risk in screen exposure itself shows that this view is not shared by every practitioner, and that disagreement is itself part of the professional landscape that adolescents and parents encounter.

Regarding SOP 2, the researchers conclude that the factors shaping adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments cannot be weighed one at a time. The adolescent's emotional state and basic needs, the family, online peers, and the game's content and cost interlock, and stress, gaming, and lost sleep can sustain one another in a cycle. Because the weight of each factor differs per adolescent and often becomes visible only over time, a single rule, such as a fixed limit on hours, cannot capture what matters in a particular case. This supports the configurational view adopted in Chapter 1 (Dienlin & Johannes, 2020) and agrees with Yang et al. (2024), who found that process, person, and contextual factors together were related to adolescents' digital media use.

Regarding SOP 3, the researchers conclude that the psychologists' practice is built on holding benefits and concerns together. Because relief, connection, and skills often coexist with disrupted sleep, self-care, and family life in the same adolescent, they avoid labeling gaming as simply good or bad and aim at regulation rather than prohibition. Their main obstacles lie less with the adolescent than with the family and with the adolescent's commitment once gaming has

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become a habit, which agrees with the practitioners in Lo et al. (2021), who found family involvement both essential and difficult. Their strategies therefore begin with understanding the adolescent and continue with gradual limits, offline alternatives, family involvement, and psychoeducation, an approach consistent with the review's evidence that communicative involvement is more promising than restriction alone (Nielsen et al., 2019).

Taken together, the accounts show that adolescent gaming calls for contextual professional judgment. What gaming provides, what it displaces, and the relationships around the adolescent mattered more to these psychologists than the number of hours played. Interviewee 5 expressed this in closing: "The goal is not to simply reduce gaming, but to understand the gamer" (49:26).

The bioecological model of Bronfenbrenner and Morris (2007) organizes these conclusions. The Person component covers the adolescent's motives, emotional state, and developmental stage. The Process component covers the repeated interaction between the adolescent and the game, including the stress cycle. The Context component covers the family, online peers, school, and wider influences such as game design, advertising, and public discussion of gaming. The Time component covers changing routines, generational differences in what gaming means, and the effect of the pandemic. The psychologists, standing outside this configuration, read it case by case, which is the interpretive position anticipated in Figure 1.

Within the literature reviewed, the existing studies measured gaming's effects or asked adolescents and social workers about their experiences, but none described how licensed psychologists in Luzon interpret and respond to adolescent gaming. This study contributes seven such accounts, including the psychologists' attention to daily functioning, their reading of gaming by function, their work with families, their use of shared experience to build rapport, and their discovery of gaming behind other presenting concerns. These accounts can inform school mental

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health services under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024), where concerns about students' gaming may be raised and referred.

Recommendations

Based on the findings and conclusions, the researchers offer the following recommendations.

Psychologists and Guidance Counselors. Psychologists and guidance counselors may include questions about gaming in routine intake, since gaming seldom arrives as the presenting concern (Theme 1.1), and may assess its function and its effect on sleep, meals, school, and relationships rather than its hours alone (Themes 1.2 and 1.3). A short set of questions, such as what happens before the adolescent plays, what the adolescent gets from playing, and what happens when play is stopped, can make this assessment routine. When gaming is a concern, limits may be agreed with the adolescent and reduced in small, scheduled steps rather than imposed at once (Themes 3.5 and 3.6).

Parents and Guardians. Parents and guardians may begin by asking adolescents why and what they play before setting rules, since parents and adolescents often read gaming differently (Theme 3.4). Limits are more likely to hold when they are agreed with the adolescent, introduced gradually, and kept consistently, including when the adolescent protests; when parents work long hours, another adult at home may be asked to carry out the schedule. Parents may also watch for early signs that gaming is displacing sleep, meals, or family time (Theme 3.2).

Schools and School Administrators. Through the Care Centers and mental health programs required under Republic Act No. 12080 (2024), schools may include gaming and sleep in their psychoeducation for students and parents, train guidance staff to ask about gaming as part of screening for daily routines, and provide offline activities, such as sports, clubs, and organized e-



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sports with clear schedules, that offer the belonging some students find in games (Themes 2.3, 3.1, and 3.6). Referral guidelines may describe gaming concerns in terms of disrupted functioning rather than screen time, so that the cases that need a psychologist reach one.

Adolescents. Adolescents may use the same signs the psychologists used, such as losing sleep, skipping meals, falling behind in school, or feeling irritable when play is interrupted, to notice when their own gaming has moved from relief to a problem, and may raise it with a trusted adult or guidance counselor (Themes 1.3 and 3.2).

Future Researchers. This study drew on seven psychologists in Luzon: five practicing in Pampanga, one in Metro Manila and Bulacan, and one in Nueva Ecija. Two of the seven answered in writing, without follow-up questions. Future studies may recruit a wider range of participants, including adolescents and parents as well as psychologists, from more provinces of Luzon. They may also examine Kapampangan and other local cultural meanings of gaming, which did not appear explicitly in these accounts; explore concerns that participants raised beyond gaming, such as doomscrolling and social media use; test claims about screen exposure and neurodivergent symptoms through appropriate designs; and follow the relationship between stress, gaming, and sleep over time through longitudinal research. Developing and evaluating a gaming-specific screening guide for school Care Centers, based on the questions about function and functioning described in this study, would turn these practitioner accounts into a tool that can be tested.

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HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Appendix A****Interview Schedule**

The interview schedule below is the Luzon version used with the participants, preceded in the participant packet by the information sheet and the informed consent form. Probes were added as needed to clarify answers and to invite concrete cases.

Preliminary Questions

1. Could you walk us through your professional background?
2. Within that, what has your work with adolescents involved?

SSOP 1: How do psychologists in Luzon describe their lived professional experiences of encountering and interpreting adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?

- 1a. In what situations, if any, has an adolescent's gaming come up in your work with them?
- 1b. Could you describe a professional experience where an adolescent's gaming became relevant to your work with them?
- 1c. Reflecting on that case, what do you notice or consider when trying to understand what gaming meant for the adolescent?
- 1d. How do you understand adolescent digital well-being in relation to gaming environments?
- 1e. How has that understanding changed over the course of your practice?

SSOP 2: How do psychologists in Luzon describe the factors that shape adolescent digital well-being in gaming environments?

- 2a. What factors do you consider when understanding how gaming relates to an adolescent's digital well-being?



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- 2b. When considering the factors you have mentioned, how do you determine which ones are most important in understanding a particular adolescent's situation?
- 2c. How do the factors you have described relate to one another in an adolescent's gaming environment?
- 2d. Can the importance of these factors vary across adolescents or situations? Why or why not?
- 2e. Can you describe an experience, if any, in which the factors you usually consider did not fully explain an adolescent's gaming situation?

SSOP 3: How do psychologists in Luzon describe their practice in responding to gaming-related concerns among adolescents, in terms of: (a) the benefits and the concerns they identify in adolescents' gaming; (b) the challenges they face as practitioners; and (c) the strategies they employ?

- 3a. What benefits of gaming have you observed among adolescents?
- 3b. What concerns related to gaming have you encountered among adolescents?
- 3c. Have you encountered cases where gaming seemed to bring both benefits and concerns for the same adolescent?
- 3d. What has been particularly challenging when responding to gaming-related concerns among adolescents?
- 3e. When you encounter a gaming-related concern, what strategies have you found useful in responding to the adolescent's situation?
- 3f. What approaches or circumstances have you found supportive of adolescents' digital well-being in relation to gaming?

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Closing Question

Is there anything about your professional experiences with adolescent gaming and digital well-being that we have not discussed but that you believe is important for this study to understand?

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Appendix B****Written Questionnaire**

The written questionnaire was administered online to eligible psychologists who could not schedule a live interview. Respondents first read the information sheet and gave consent, then answered the items below in their own words. Any item could be left blank, and respondents could state that an experience had not occurred.

Eligibility

1. Are you a PRC-licensed psychologist (RPsy)?
2. Have you worked professionally with adolescents (junior or senior high school age)?
3. Does your professional practice serve clients in Luzon?

Profile

1. How many years have you practiced as a licensed psychologist?
2. Which field best describes your main area of practice?
3. In which settings do you work with adolescents? (Select all that apply.)
4. About what share of your current clients are adolescents?
5. In which province is your main practice located?

Questions

The written version contains the two preliminary questions, items 1a to 3f, and the closing question of Appendix A, with these additions: after item 1b, “How typical is that case of what you usually encounter?” and an optional explanation; after item 2d, an optional “Could you tell us a little about why?”; and before item 2e, a yes-or-no question asking whether the respondent has had an experience the usual factors did not fully explain. The form closes by asking which questions, if

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any, were unclear, whether a researcher may email short clarifying questions, and whether the respondent would like a summary of the findings.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Appendix C****Codebook: Codes by Theme**

The table lists the 86 codes developed during analysis, the theme to which each code belongs, and the number of extracts coded with it. Code labels are written in plain words, using the participants' own phrases where possible.

Table C1

Codes, Themes, and Number of Extracts

Code	Code label	Theme	Extracts
C001	Gaming surfaces behind another presenting concern	1.1	6
C002	Gaming is rarely the main case	1.1	4
C003	Gaming sits within wider screen use	1.1	1
C004	Adolescent arrives reluctant or ashamed	1.1	1
C005	Doom scrolling matters more than gaming	1.1	1
C006	Gaming as escape and coping	1.2	7
C007	Function over frequency	1.2	6
C008	Gaming carries personal meaning	1.2	3
C009	Gaming as a sign of a deeper problem	1.2	2
C010	Making sense of gaming with the adolescent	1.2	1
C011	Gaming activity signals distress	1.2	1
C012	Well-being as balance and control	1.3	3
C014	Sleep as the basic marker of well-being	1.3	1
C015	Gaming as a lifeline for well-being	1.3	1
C016	Screen exposure reshapes the developing brain	1.3	2
C017	Shift from judging to understanding	1.4	5
C018	Generational gap in what gaming means	1.4	1
C019	Gaming has become accepted and normal	1.4	1
C020	Developmental lens on adolescents	1.4	1
C021	Pandemic sharpened concern about screens	1.4	2
C022	Understand the gamer, not only control the gaming	1.4	2
C023	Online friendship recognized as real	1.4	1
C024	Emotional state and stressor behind play	2.1	5
C025	Motive and purpose of play	2.1	4
C026	Pattern and amount of play	2.1	1
C027	Basic needs come first	2.1	2
C028	Psychological and clinical history	2.1	1

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Code	Code label	Theme	Extracts
C029	Family as a source of stress	2.2	2
C030	Family support and supervision	2.2	1
C031	Gaming as escape from a harmful home or trauma	2.2	1
C086	Supportive environment as protection	2.2	1
C032	Online friendship and belonging	2.3	2
C033	Harmful online influence	2.3	3
C034	Game content and immersion	2.4	1
C035	Spending and the gaming economy	2.4	4
C036	Gaming as an emerging career	2.4	1
C037	Ads and peers pull adolescents in	2.4	1
C038	Gaming blamed in public incidents	2.4	3
C039	Evidence over assumption	2.4	1
C040	Factors form a cycle	2.5	4
C041	Risk weighed against protective factors	2.5	1
C042	Importance varies by adolescent and context	2.5	8
C043	Hidden reasons surface only over time	2.5	4
C044	Small cues carry meaning	2.5	2
C045	Outcome unknown when clients stop coming	2.5	1
C046	From leisure to habit to dysfunction	2.5	1
C047	Weight goes to what is tied to current distress	2.5	2
C048	Relaxation and stress relief	3.1	4
C049	Social connection and belonging (benefit)	3.1	3
C050	Cognitive and teamwork skills	3.1	3
C051	Safe space for introverted or neurodivergent adolescents	3.1	2
C013	Dysfunction, not hours, is the threshold	3.2	4
C052	Loss of sleep and self-care	3.2	3
C053	Academic decline and school avoidance	3.2	1
C054	Aggression and withdrawal when gaming is stopped	3.2	2
C055	Isolation and physical inactivity	3.2	1
C056	Loss of control	3.2	3
C057	Screen-mediated neurodivergent symptoms	3.2	1
C058	Exposure to harmful content and predators	3.2	2
C059	Little psychological concern observed	3.2	2
C060	Multitasking students keep high grades	3.2	1
C061	Habit carried into adulthood	3.2	1
C062	Benefits and concerns coexist	3.3	9
C063	Benefits hold only within limits	3.3	3
C064	Parents see gaming as the whole problem	3.4	1
C065	Parents excuse or cannot enforce limits	3.4	5

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Code	Code label	Theme	Extracts
C066	Distinguishing primary problem from coping response	3.4	1
C067	Engaging the adolescent's commitment to change	3.4	2
C068	Gaming as the only coping the adolescent accepts	3.4	2
C069	Adolescent detached from family	3.4	1
C070	Advice alone does not change the habit	3.4	1
C071	Non-judgmental, curious stance	3.5	5
C072	Common ground and self-disclosure	3.5	6
C073	Give the adolescent a voice in the plan	3.5	2
C074	Bridging parent and adolescent	3.5	3
C075	Holistic assessment	3.5	2
C076	Learning strategies through curiosity and trial	3.5	1
C077	Supportive gaming communities and events	3.5	1
C078	Gradual regulation, not prohibition	3.6	5
C079	Offline alternatives and physical activity	3.6	4
C080	Psychoeducation	3.6	1
C081	Recommending restorative games	3.6	1
C082	Safer substitutes for risky play	3.6	1
C083	Gaming built into a treatment plan	3.6	1
C084	Technology cannot be removed, only balanced	3.6	1
C085	Practitioner self-care	Not themed	1
Total			203

Note. Codes are numbered in the order they were created. Theme numbers follow Table 2. Counts include the 12 extracts from Interviewee 7.

HOLY ANGEL UNIVERSITY**Appendix D****Negative Cases**

The table lists the accounts that contradicted or qualified a theme, the reason each did not fit, and how it was handled. All of them are reported within the relevant theme in Chapter 3.

Table D1*Negative Cases and How They Were Reported*

Extract	Source	Theme affected	What the account showed
EX-052	Interviewee 2, 30:54	Theme 2.5	Reported never meeting a case that the usual factors failed to explain.
EX-055	Interviewee 2, 33:22	Theme 3.2	Saw no psychological concern because students cope well, while naming sleep loss and spending.
EX-056	Interviewee 2, 35:44	Theme 3.3	Had not encountered a case with both benefits and concerns.
EX-096	Interviewee 3, 40:45	Theme 1.1	Found doomscrolling, not gaming, to be the main digital concern in practice.
EX-104	Interviewee 4, 10:03	Themes 1.2, 1.3	Located harm in passive screen exposure itself, whatever its function or content.
EX-105	Interviewee 4, 10:22	Themes 1.2, 1.3	Linked screen-shaped self-regulation to crisis among overwhelmed children.
EX-106	Interviewee 4, 04:44	Theme 1.4	Understanding moved toward greater concern after the pandemic.
EX-107	Interviewee 4, 06:52	Theme 1.4	Formed the hypothesis that screen time length affects mental health.
EX-120	Interviewee 4, 18:24	Theme 3.2	Attributed ADHD- and autism-like symptoms to early screen exposure (tentative term).
EX-153	Interviewee 5, 34:08	Theme 3.2	Students who game for hours and still keep high grades.
EX-173	Interviewee 6, item 3a	Theme 3.1	Not sure of any benefit (written, no follow-up).
EX-175	Interviewee 6, item 3c	Theme 3.3	Had not encountered a case with both (written, no follow-up).

Note. All twelve accounts were reported as given within the theme they qualify; Theme 1.4 was redefined to state that one participant moved toward greater concern.